



VAKO CLUB

The World *of the Glass*

*Grapes, regions and pairings
for understanding what you are drinking*

El mundo de la copa

An enthusiast's guide

2026 EDITION



The World of the Glass

An enthusiast's guide: grapes, regions and pairings

English edition of *El mundo de la copa*

Published by **Vako Club** · First edition, 2026

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Drinking alcohol is the responsibility of each adult. This work is intended for cultural and gastronomic purposes.

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INTRODUCTION

How to use this guide

A map to find your bearings, not an exam to pass

There are two ways of approaching wine. One consists of memorising appellations, vintages and scores; the other, of understanding why a wine tastes the way it does. This guide chooses the second. Not because the facts do not matter — there are plenty in these pages — but because facts without structure are forgotten, whereas structure, once grasped, applies to any bottle that turns up in front of you.

The book is designed to be read in order the first time and consulted out of sequence afterwards. **Part I** explains the mechanics: what components are in a glass, how place modifies them and what the winery does with them. **Part II** turns that into a workable tasting method, free of affected vocabulary. **Part III** is a catalogue of varieties designed for quick reference: each grape takes a single page and always follows the same structure, so that comparing two entries is immediate. **Parts IV and V** cover the regions of the world and the table.

How to read a grape entry

The **profile bars** — body, acidity, tannin, alcohol and ageing potential — are relative values: they show where that variety sits in relation to the others, not the measurement of any particular bottle. The **key regions** table points to the places where the grape reaches distinct expressions. The **pairings** are tested starting points, not obligations. And the **sommelier's note** supplies the piece of information that tends to separate knowing a wine's name from understanding it.

A USEFUL WARNING

No aromatic description is an instruction. If you find plum rather than violet in a Malbec, you are not wrong: the perception of smell varies from person to person for proven genetic reasons. The descriptors in this guide are shared vocabulary for communicating, not a truth to be confirmed.

Three habits worth more than a hundred facts

- ♦ **Always compare.** Two glasses side by side teach more than ten bottles spread over months. Taste memory is short; direct comparison is immediate.
- ♦ **Write one line.** A full tasting sheet is not required: a single sentence per bottle — name, year and what struck you — builds judgement within months.
- ♦ **Mind the temperature.** It is the variable that ruins the most wines and the easiest to fix. A red served at 24 °C tastes of alcohol; the same wine at 16 °C seems like another bottle.



I

PART ONE

Foundations

Before touring the world it helps to know what you are looking at: the components of wine, the influence of place and the decisions taken in the winery.

ANATOMY OF A GLASS

TERROIR

FROM VINEYARD TO BOTTLE

OAK



CHAPTER ONE

Anatomy of a glass

The five components that explain almost everything

Every wine, whatever its origin or its price, can be described with five variables: sweetness, acidity, tannin, alcohol and body. Learning to identify them separately is the step that turns «I like it» into «I understand why I like it», and it is what allows you to anticipate how a bottle will behave at the table before you pull the cork.

Sweetness

This is the sugar left unfermented. The scale runs from *dry* — under four grams per litre, imperceptible to most people — to dessert wines, which exceed a hundred. One important detail: ripe fruit on the nose does not imply sugar on the palate. Many intensely fruity reds are technically dry; what registers as sweetness is in fact aromatic intensity combined with alcohol.

Acidity

This is the backbone of a wine and the component that decides its longevity and its usefulness at the table. It is felt as salivation along the sides of the tongue. Cool climates preserve the grape's natural acidity; warm ones degrade it during ripening. A wine without enough acidity comes across as flat and tires you by the second glass, however concentrated it may be.

Tannin

Phenolic compounds that come from the skins, the seeds and, to a lesser extent, from wood. They are not a flavour but a tactile sensation: astringency, dryness in the gums, that impression of the tongue sticking to the palate. They appear mainly in reds, because the must ferments in contact with the skins. Good tannins register as firm but polished; poorly handled ones, as rough and bitter.

THE TEA TRICK

To calibrate the sensation of tannin, leave a black tea bag in water for ten minutes and taste it. That rasping dryness is pure tannin, with no fruit or alcohol to disguise it. Once identified, it becomes impossible to confuse.

Alcohol

The product of sugar fermentation. It is felt as warmth in the throat and as volume in the middle of the mouth. The degree depends above all on how ripe the grape was at harvest, and therefore on climate: wines from warm areas hover around 14–15 %, whereas a Mosel Riesling may stop at 8 %. Alcohol is neither good nor bad in itself; the problem arises when it stands out above everything else and is perceived in isolation.

Body

This is the sensation of weight and density on the palate: the combined result of the four elements above plus the dry extract. The usual analogy — water, skimmed milk, whole milk, cream — remains the most effective. A light wine is not inferior to a full-bodied one: they are different tools for different situations.

COMPONENT	WHERE YOU FEEL IT	SIGN THAT IT IS LACKING OR EXCESSIVE
Sweetness	Tip of the tongue, first impression	Cloying if acidity does not support it
Acidity	Sides of the tongue; salivation	Without it, the wine tires and fades
Tannin	Gums and palate; a tactile sensation	In excess it scrapes and turns the finish bitter
Alcohol	Warmth in the throat	If it stands alone, it buries the fruit
Body	Overall weight in the mouth	Light is no fault; hollow is

Balance, which is not a component

None of these five elements determines quality on its own. What separates a remarkable wine from a merely correct one is the proportion between them: acidity supporting the fruit, tannin with enough material to wrap around, alcohol that never protrudes. A balanced wine is not necessarily a soft one; it may be taut, austere and structured. Balance means that no part is apologising for the others.

Length: the final test

After swallowing, count the seconds the flavour lingers. Under five suggests a simple wine; between five and ten, a well-made one; more than fifteen is usually reserved for wines of exceptional origin and craft. Length is the one indicator of quality that does not depend on personal taste: it is measurable, and practically impossible to fake.

CHAPTER TWO

Terroir

Why the same grape does not taste the same in two different places

The French word *terroir* has no exact translation because it does not name a single thing. It gathers the soil, the climate, the topography and the human tradition of a particular place, and asserts that this combination leaves a recognisable mark on the wine. It is a contested idea — some regard it as marketing elevated to doctrine — but the practical evidence is hard to ignore: two parcels a hundred metres apart, with the same variety and the same winemaker, produce wines a trained taster can tell apart.



Climate: the dominant factor

If a single element had to be chosen, it would be this one. Climate determines how much sugar the grape accumulates, how much acidity it retains and which family of aromas it develops. The general rule is simple and surprisingly reliable: **the more heat, the riper the fruit, the higher the alcohol and the lower the acidity; the more coolness, the more red or citrus fruit, the less alcohol and the more tension.**

That is why classical viticulture historically concentrated between the 30th and 50th parallels in both hemispheres. Outside that band it is either too cold to ripen or too hot to keep any freshness. Exceptions exist and are increasingly numerous, but they are achieved by correcting with another factor: almost always, altitude.

DIURNAL RANGE

The difference between the daytime maximum and the night-time minimum matters as much as the average. Daytime heat ripens the grape; night-time cold slows the breakdown of acids and fixes colour and aroma. Mendoza, with swings of 15 °C or more, owes much of its character to this.

Altitude: portable climate

Every hundred metres of elevation lowers the mean temperature by around 0.6 °C. A vineyard at 1,500 metres in Salta, at an almost tropical latitude, has a thermal regime comparable to that of regions far closer to the pole. Ultraviolet radiation also increases with height, and the vine responds by thickening its skins: more colour, more tannin, more anthocyanins. This is the mechanism behind the intensity of high-altitude reds.

Soil: less flavour, more behaviour

This is where most mythology accumulates. Soil does not transfer flavours directly: a vine planted on slate does not produce a wine that tastes of slate. What soil does is condition the *behaviour* of the plant, above all through drainage and water availability.

SOIL	EFFECT ON THE VINE	EMBLEMATIC EXAMPLE
Gravel	Excellent drainage and heat retention; forces the root to go deep	Médoc, Bordeaux
Limestone	Holds moisture and releases it slowly; linked to acidity and a mineral profile	Chablis · Sancerre
Slate	Absorbs and returns heat at night; allows ripening in cold climates	Mosel, Germany
Clay	Cool and retentive; gives wines more body and colour	Pomerol, Bordeaux
Sand	Poor and loose; paler, lighter wines. Resists phylloxera	Colares, Portugal
Stony alluvium	Extreme drainage; concentration through controlled water stress	Uco Valley, Mendoza

Stress: the paradox of the vine

The vine is one of the few cultivated plants that bears better fruit when it suffers. Fertile, well-irrigated soil produces a great deal of mediocre grapes: the plant spends its energy on leaves and shoots. Poor soil with limited water, by contrast, forces it to concentrate resources into few bunches, with thicker skins and a higher proportion of aromatic compounds. Hence the phrase common in wineries: the best land for the vine is the worst land for everything else.

The human hand

Terroir includes decisions: which variety to plant, at what density, how to train the plant, when to harvest. The same site interpreted by two growers gives different wines. This does not weaken the concept: it completes it. Terroir is not geological determinism but a long conversation between a place and the people who work it, sustained at times for centuries until a recognisable style emerges.

A great wine is not made in the winery. It is made in the vineyard and looked after in the winery.

A WINEMAKING MAXIM

How climate translates into the glass

This table summarises the practical effect of climate on a single variety. It works as a mental shortcut in blind tasting: once the profile is identified, the likely origin is halved.

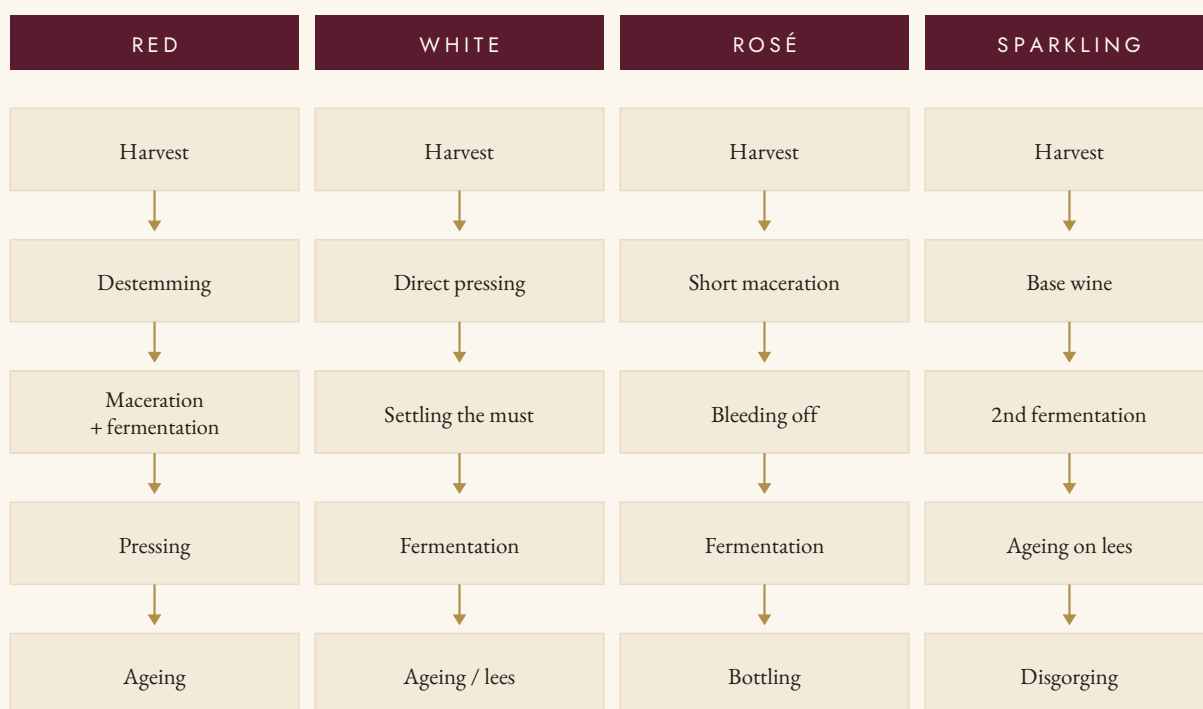
TRAIT	COOL CLIMATE	WARM CLIMATE
Fruit	Red, citric, somewhat green	Black, tropical, candied
Acidity	High and marked	Medium to low
Alcohol	11–13 %	13.5–15.5 %
Tannin	Firm, at times angular	Abundant but ripe
Body	Light to medium	Medium to full
Examples	Mosel · Burgundy · Loire · Patagonia	Barossa · Napa · Southern Italy · Cafayate

CHAPTER THREE

From vineyard to bottle

The decisions that turn grapes into wine

Fermentation is a natural process: yeasts consume the sugar in the grape and produce alcohol and carbon dioxide. Everything else — the colour, the texture, the style — depends on human decisions taken before, during and after it. Knowing them lets you read a wine backwards: to notice a trait in the glass and deduce what was done to achieve it.



THE FOUR BASIC ROUTES OF WINEMAKING

The real difference between red and white

It lies not in the colour of the grape but in contact with the skin. The pulp of almost all red varieties is colourless: juice freshly pressed from Malbec is transparent. Colour, tannin and much of the structure are extracted during **maceration**, when the must ferments together with the skins. For whites the fruit is pressed first and the clean juice fermented; hence they are pale and practically tannin-free. A rosé is not a blend: it is a red with only a few hours of maceration.

Malolactic fermentation

A second fermentation, bacterial and non-alcoholic, that converts malic acid — sharp, of green apple — into lactic acid, which is softer. Practically every red goes through it. In whites it is a stylistic decision: a white Burgundy with full malolactic gains a creamy texture and buttery notes; a Loire Sauvignon Blanc avoids it to preserve its citrus edge.

Ageing on the lees

Lees are the remains of dead yeasts that settle after fermentation. Keeping the wine in contact with them, stirring periodically — *bâtonnage* — adds volume, aromas of bread and brioche and greater resistance to oxidation. It is the technique behind the texture of great white Burgundy and the complexity of long-aged Champagne.

Sparkling wines: where the bubbles come from

METHOD	HOW IT WORKS	RESULT
Traditional (champenoise)	Second fermentation inside the bottle itself, with long ageing on the lees	Fine, persistent bubble; notes of toast
Charmat	Second fermentation in a pressurised steel tank; bottled afterwards	Crisp fruit and flowers; looser bubble
Ancestral	Bottled before the first fermentation has finished	Cloudy, lightly sparkling, very expressive
Carbonated	Direct injection of carbon dioxide	Coarse, short-lived bubble; budget range

Where the sugar in sweet wines comes from

- ◆ **Late harvest.** The grape stays on the vine until it dehydrates and concentrates sugar. Alsace, Germany, the Loire.
- ◆ **Botrytis, or «noble rot».** A fungus pierces the skin and evaporates water, concentrating sugar and contributing aromas of honey and saffron. Sauternes, Tokaj.
- ◆ **Ice wine.** The grapes are picked frozen and pressed still frozen: the ice crystals stay behind. Canada, Germany, Austria.
- ◆ **Drying.** Bunches are dried on mats before fermenting. Amarone and Recioto in the Veneto, straw wines of the Jura.
- ◆ **Fortification.** Grape spirit is added during fermentation to stop it: the unfermented sugar remains. Port, Muscat.

Filtration, fining and the «natural» label

Before bottling, most wines are fined and filtered to remove suspended particles. Both processes bring stability and visual clarity, and both can also subtract some texture and aromatic nuance. Hence a growing number of producers choose to bottle unfiltered, accepting a degree of cloudiness as part of the style.

The term «natural wine» has no legal definition in almost any country. In practice it denotes wines made with minimal intervention: indigenous yeasts, little or no added sulphite, unfiltered. The category includes extraordinary work and also unstable bottles; it is best judged by producer rather than by label.

Something similar applies to «organic» and «biodynamic». The first is regulated and certifies vineyard management without synthetic agrochemicals. The second adds a lunar calendar and specific preparations, and attracts scientific scepticism; even so, many of its practitioners are among the most meticulous growers in the world, which explains a good part of their results.

SULPHITES IN PROPORTION

Sulphur dioxide is an antioxidant and antimicrobial, and has been used in wine since antiquity. Fermentation produces sulphites on its own, so sulphite-free wine does not exist. A conventional red contains considerably less than many packets of dried fruit. The mandatory label warning addresses infrequent allergies, not a general risk.

Reading the process from the glass

WHAT YOU NOTICE	WHAT PROBABLY HAPPENED
Butter and a creamy texture in a white	Full malolactic and ageing on the lees
Vanilla, coconut or cocoa	New barrel; American oak if there is coconut
Pale colour in a red	A thin-skinned variety or a short maceration
Fine bubble and a scent of toast	Traditional method with years on the lees
Slight cloudiness and a cider note	Unfiltered; possibly low-intervention winemaking

CHAPTER FOUR

Oak and other vessels

What wood contributes and how to tell when there is too much

The barrel began as a shipping container and ended up as an ingredient. An oak vessel does not merely hold wine: it gives up aromatic compounds, allows a slow micro-oxygenation that softens tannin, and slightly concentrates the liquid through evaporation. Used with judgement, it adds complexity; used to excess, it erases the wine's origin.

French, American and other oaks

ORIGIN	AROMATIC CONTRIBUTION	TEXTURE
French	Subtle vanilla, sweet spice, clove, cedar	Fine grain; slow release
American	Coconut, dill, intense vanilla	Wide grain; rapid release
Hungarian and Slovenian	An intermediate, more discreet profile	Widely used in Italy and Spain

Toast and the age of the barrel

During manufacture the staves are heated to bend them, and that toasting — light, medium or heavy — transforms the wood. A light toast preserves notes of coconut and vanilla; a heavy one contributes coffee, cocoa and smoke. Age matters as much as origin: a new barrel gives up a great deal of character, and by its third or fourth use it is nearly neutral, useful only for controlled oxygenation. That is why technical sheets state the percentage of new oak: it is a fact about style, not about quality.

HOW TO SPOT TOO MUCH WOOD

Smell the glass and then swirl it. If aromas of vanilla, coconut or coffee arrive first and the fruit is hard to find, the oak is smothering the wine. Another sign: a bitter, dry finish that comes not from grape tannin but from the wood, leaving a sawn sensation on the palate.

Beyond oak

- ◆ **Stainless steel.** Neutral and airtight. Preserves fruit and freshness; the standard choice for aromatic whites and young reds.
- ◆ **Concrete.** Making a strong comeback. It allows some micro-oxygenation without giving up aromas, and its thermal inertia stabilises fermentation. Concrete eggs also encourage the natural movement of the lees.
- ◆ **Clay amphorae.** Recovered from the Georgian tradition — the *qvevri* — and from Mediterranean antiquity. They contribute texture and a slight earthy note.
- ◆ **Foudres and large casks.** From 2,000 to 10,000 litres. Less wood surface per litre of wine: oxygenation without the flavour of oak. Common in Barolo and the Rhône.

Translating the back label

WHAT IT SAYS	WHAT IT MEANS IN THE GLASS
100 % new French oak	A marked wood signature; it needs a concentrated wine to carry it
30 % new oak, 12 months	Balanced use; the fruit should still be in front
Second- and third-use barrels	Almost no wood aroma; the aim is texture and oxygenation
Foudre or 5,000-litre cask	Traditional style; the wood is imperceptible
Unoaked	Steel or concrete; maximum varietal expression
Reserva · Gran Reserva	In Spain, regulated minimum times in barrel and bottle

A word about oak chips

In the affordable price range it is common to use oak *chips* or staves suspended in steel tanks. The practice is legal in most markets and is no fraud, but it produces a flatter, superimposed wood aroma without the integration that time in barrel provides. You can recognise it because the vanilla arrives sharp and isolated, as though added at the end.



II

PART TWO

Learning to taste

Tasting is not a gift: it is a method. Five steps, a shared vocabulary and the discipline of comparing.

TASTING IN FIVE STEPS

THE AROMA WHEEL

SERVING AND KEEPING



CHAPTER FIVE

Tasting in five steps

A repeatable method, without the solemnity

Professional tasting does not set out to decide whether a wine is likeable, but to describe it precisely enough for someone else to recognise it. That apparently technical aim is what makes it useful to anyone: it forces orderly attention instead of an instant verdict. Five steps are enough.

1 · Sight

Tilt the glass over a white background and look at the rim. **Intensity** suggests concentration and variety: a pale Pinot Noir and an opaque Malbec are distinguishable before you smell them. **Hue** reveals age. Young reds have a purple rim; over the years they turn ruby and then brick. Whites travel the opposite way: from greenish to gold and amber. The «legs» that run down the side indicate alcohol and sugar, not quality.

2 · The nose at rest

Smell before swirling. The most volatile compounds come off first and tend to be the most delicate fruit and floral aromas. This first impression also reveals faults: a smell of wet cardboard or damp cellar indicates *cork taint*; vinegar or nail polish, elevated volatile acidity; struck match, reduction — which often blows off with air.

3 · The nose in motion

Swirl the glass to increase the surface for evaporation and smell again. Now the heavier molecules appear: spice, wood, tertiary notes of age. Try to sort what you find into families before hunting for exact descriptors: first decide whether it is fruit, flower, herb, spice or toast; refine only afterwards.

PRIMARY, SECONDARY AND TERTIARY AROMAS

Primary: they come from the grape — fruit, flowers, herbal notes. **Secondary:** they arise from fermentation and lees ageing — butter, bread, yeast. **Tertiary:** they result from ageing in barrel and bottle — leather, tobacco, mushroom, walnut. Telling them apart lets you estimate a wine's age with remarkable accuracy.

4 · The palate

Take a moderate sip and run mentally through the five components in a fixed order: sweetness, acidity, tannin, alcohol, body. The order matters because it stops the general impression from burying the details. Drawing a little air between your teeth with the wine in your mouth — an inelegant but effective manoeuvre — volatilises the aromas towards the retronasal passage, where most of what we call «flavour» actually happens.

5 · Finish and conclusion

Swallow or spit, and count. **Length** is measured in seconds and is the most reliable indicator of quality. Then formulate a conclusion in a single sentence: which variety it might be, from what climate, what age it appears, which dish it would suit. Being wrong is part of the method; what builds judgement is having risked an answer before looking at the label.

How to organise a tasting at home

- ♦ **In pairs.** Direct comparison teaches more than any description. The same variety from two regions, or the same region in two vintages.
- ♦ **Blind, even partly.** Covering the bottle removes the bias of price and label, which is far greater than anyone likes to admit.
- ♦ **From lighter to heavier.** Whites before reds, young before old, dry before sweet, light before structured.
- ♦ **No perfume, no cooking under way.** The sense of smell saturates quickly and the room competes with the glass.
- ♦ **Water and bread, nothing else.** Cheese, counterintuitively, flatters almost every wine and distorts the comparison.

Tasting is simply paying attention in a set order. Everything else is vocabulary.

ON METHOD

The aroma wheel

A shared vocabulary for naming what you smell

Work from the centre outwards: first identify the family, then the group, and only then look for the precise descriptor.

Naming an aroma is, to a large extent, learning to find it the next time.



CHAPTER SEVEN

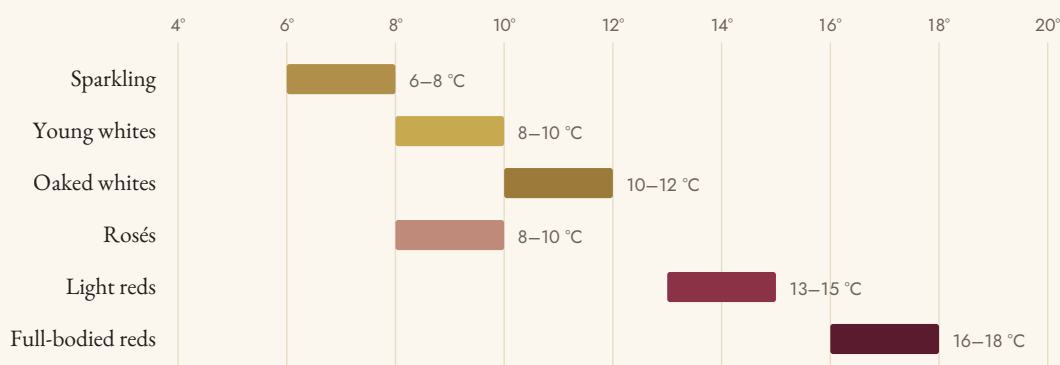
Serving and keeping

Temperature, glassware, decanting and what to do with an open bottle

A properly made wine can be ruined in the final five minutes. Serving temperature, the glass and the moment of opening alter what reaches the palate as much as many cellar decisions, with the difference that here the correction lies entirely in the hands of whoever is pouring.

Temperature: the decisive variable

Heat exaggerates alcohol and flattens aromas; excessive cold mutes them and hardens tannin. The most useful rule of thumb is to serve reds a little cooler and whites a little less cold than custom dictates: the former usually reach the table at room temperature — which in summer exceeds 25 °C — and the latter straight from the fridge, at 4 °C.



Decanting: when to and when not to

- ♦ **Young, structured reds.** Yes, decisively: half an hour to an hour of air softens the tannin and unfurls the fruit.
- ♦ **Old reds, fifteen years or more.** Yes, but only to separate the sediment, and serve at once. Prolonged air can take them apart in minutes.
- ♦ **Oaked whites.** They often improve; a small decanter is enough.
- ♦ **Sparkling wine.** Never. You lose the gas, which is part of its structure.

The glass matters more than it seems

You do not need a different glass for every variety; two shapes cover almost everything. What counts is thin, colourless glass, a stem — so the hand does not warm the wine — and a mouth narrower than the bowl, so that the aromas gather. Fill to a third, never more.

SHAPE	WHAT IT IS FOR	WINES
Wide bowl (Burgundy)	A large surface in contact with air; lifts delicate aromas	Pinot Noir, Nebbiolo, oaked whites
Tall tulip (Bordeaux)	Directs the wine to the centre of the tongue and tempers tannin	Cabernet, Malbec, Syrah
Standard white glass	Smaller volume; keeps the temperature down	Sauvignon Blanc, Riesling
Flute or slim glass	Preserves the bubble; a wide glass disperses it	Sparkling wines

The open bottle

Once uncorked, the enemy is oxygen. Stoppering and refrigerating — reds included — extends the life noticeably: a full-bodied red lasts three to five days, a fresh white two or three, and a sparkling wine barely one, even with a pressure stopper. Decanting the remainder into a smaller bottle, filled to the top, is the most effective household method: it reduces the air in contact without any equipment.

The most frequent faults

FAULT	HOW IT PRESENTS	CAN IT BE FIXED?
Cork taint (TCA)	Wet cardboard, damp cellar; the fruit disappears	No. Return the bottle
Oxidation	Browned apple, walnut; a dulled colour	No, if premature
Reduction	Struck match, burnt rubber, egg	Yes: aerate or decant
Volatile acidity	Vinegar, nail-polish remover	No, at high levels
Brettanomyces	Leather, farmyard, sticking plaster	In small doses, some value it
Heat damage	Cooked fruit, pushed-out cork	No. Usually poor transport

III

PART THREE

The grapes

*Eight varieties that account for most of what the world drinks.
Every entry follows the same structure so that comparing them is
immediate.*

FIVE ESSENTIAL REDS

THREE BENCHMARK WHITES



Cabernet Sauvignon

RED · BORDEAUX, FRANCE

The queen of red grapes · A natural crossing of Cabernet Franc and Sauvignon Blanc, confirmed by DNA in 1996

If a single grape could stand for the idea of a structured red wine, this would be it. Small-berried and thick-skinned, it delivers an extremely high skin-to-pulp ratio: deep colour, abundant tannin and an ageing capacity few varieties match. It buds late and ripens late, which keeps it safe from spring frost but makes it demanding in cool climates, where it can stay green.

HOW TO RECOGNISE IT

Deep colour with a purple rim in youth. On the nose, blackcurrant is almost always present, joined by cedar and graphite. On the palate the tannin is firm and somewhat angular across the middle of the tongue, and acidity carries the finish. A note of green pepper signals incomplete ripeness: these are pyrazines, the chemical markers characteristic of the Cabernet family.

IN THE GLASS

Blackcurrant	Black plum	Cedar	Graphite	Tobacco	Mint
Green pepper					

KEY REGION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Médoc, Bordeaux	Elegant and restrained; blended with Merlot and Cabernet Franc
Napa Valley, USA	Ripe fruit, polished texture, sweet oak
Maipo, Chile	Crisp blackcurrant and a distinctive minty note
Coonawarra, Australia	Terra rossa soils; eucalyptus and firm acidity
Bolgheri, Italy	The «super Tuscans»; Mediterranean herbs

PROFILE



FOOD PAIRINGS

- ◆ Grilled steak or short ribs
- ◆ Lamb with rosemary
- ◆ Hard, aged cheeses
- ◆ Grilled portobello mushrooms
- ◆ Dark chocolate (70 %+)

SERVING

16–18 °C, in a wide Bordeaux glass. Decant for 45–60 minutes if under five years old.

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

Green pepper is not a fault in itself: in cool Bordeaux or in Chile it is part of the identity. It becomes a fault only when it dominates and buries the fruit.

IF YOU LIKE THIS GRAPE, TRY ALSO

Cabernet Franc

Its parent: more floral and herbal, with lighter tannin

Carmenère

A Bordeaux cousin settled in Chile; peppery, softer in texture

Tannat

Uruguay and Madiran; even more tannic and built for the long haul

Merlot

RED · BORDEAUX, FRANCE

The perfect counterweight · Offspring of Cabernet Franc and the nearly extinct Magdeleine Noire des Charentes

Unfairly dismissed as the «easy» variety, Merlot is in fact the most widely planted grape in Bordeaux and the one behind some of the most expensive wines on earth. It ripens earlier than Cabernet Sauvignon and produces larger, thinner-skinned berries: less tannin, more pulp, a rounder texture. Its virtue is also its risk — in warm sites with high yields it turns soft and anonymous.

HOW TO RECOGNISE IT

Ruby red of medium to deep intensity. Ripe red and black fruit — plum above all — with a touch of cocoa and dried herbs. The attack is soft and the tannin registers as velvety, almost without edges. A serious Merlot is distinguished by its mid-palate: volume without heaviness.

IN THE GLASS

Plum

Black cherry

Cocoa

Bay leaf

Leather

Vanilla

KEY REGION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Pomerol, Bordeaux	Clay and iron in the soil; a texture like velvet
Saint-Émilion, Bordeaux	Blended with Cabernet Franc; floral and fresh
Colchagua, Chile	Generous black fruit and sweet tannins
Friuli and Veneto, Italy	A lighter, herbal style; highly food-friendly
Washington, USA	Balance between ripeness and firm acidity

PROFILE

BODY

ACIDITY

TANNINS

ALCOHOL

AGEING

FOOD PAIRINGS

- ◆ Pork with mustard
- ◆ Pasta with tomato and meat sauces
- ◆ Breaded veal with tomato and cheese
- ◆ Semi-hard cheeses
- ◆ Roasted aubergine

SERVING

15–17°C. It needs no long decanting; half an hour open is usually enough.

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

Much of the Merlot planted in Chile before the 1990s turned out to be Carmenère. The confusion was only cleared up in 1994.

IF YOU LIKE THIS GRAPE, TRY ALSO

Carmenère

Similar black fruit, with a spiced and herbal twist

Cabernet Franc

Comparable structure with floral perfume and graphite

Young Tempranillo

Plum and an approachable texture, with more leather

Pinot Noir

RED · BURGUNDY, FRANCE

The most difficult grape in the world · Documented since the fourth century; genetically unstable, with hundreds of clones

Pinot Noir is thin-skinned, tight-clustered and early-ripening: it rots in humidity, bakes in heat and loses perfume at high yields. In exchange, in exactly the right place, it produces wines of an aromatic transparency no other grape achieves. It is the variety that best translates the soil, which is why Burgundy built on it a map of parcels more detailed than that of any other region on earth.

HOW TO RECOGNISE IT

Pale colour — light ruby, sometimes almost translucent — which misleads entirely about its intensity. A nose of strawberry and fresh cherry that turns, with the years, to forest floor, mushroom and black tea. On the palate, silky tannin and high acidity: it feels light yet persistent. If a red is pale and still leaves the palate humming, it is almost certainly Pinot Noir.

IN THE GLASS

Strawberry

Cherry

Violet

Forest floor

Mushroom

Black tea

Clove

KEY REGION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Côte de Nuits, Burgundy	The benchmark; perfume and mineral tension
Champagne, France	Vinified as a white wine; lends body to sparkling blends
Willamette, Oregon	Pure red fruit and natural acidity
Central Otago, New Zealand	Concentrated, with notes of wild thyme
Patagonia, Argentina	Río Negro and Neuquén; freshness and crisp fruit

PROFILE

BODY

ACIDITY

TANNINS

ALCOHOL

AGEING

FOOD PAIRINGS

- ◆ Grilled salmon
- ◆ Duck with orange
- ◆ Mushroom risotto
- ◆ Pork with apples
- ◆ Washed-rind cheeses

SERVING

13–15 °C, slightly cool. A wide-bowled glass to open up the perfume.

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

Served at summer room temperature it loses everything. Fifteen minutes in the fridge before opening changes the wine completely.

IF YOU LIKE THIS GRAPE, TRY ALSO

Gamay

Beaujolais; even lighter, juicier and full of red fruit

Nerello Mascalese

Etna, Sicily; pale, mineral and tannic

Trousseau

Jura; delicate and saline, for those hunting rarities

Syrah / Shiraz

RED · RHÔNE VALLEY, FRANCE

Two names, two philosophies · A natural crossing of Dureza and Mondeuse Blanche, from south-eastern France

Syrah is the variety that best illustrates how climate rewrites a grape. In the northern Rhône — Hermitage, Côte-Rôtie — it gives medium-bodied wines, spiced and almost wild. In Australia's Barossa, under the name Shiraz, it becomes an opulent red, sweet with fruit and high in alcohol. Same plant; everything else changes.

HOW TO RECOGNISE IT

Very dark colour, almost opaque. The aromatic marker is black pepper, produced by a molecule called rotundone that survives better in cool climates. Alongside it, blackberry, black olive and a smoky or cured-meat note. The tannin is abundant but more enveloping than Cabernet's.

IN THE GLASS

Black pepper

Blackberry

Black olive

Smoked bacon

Violet

Liquorice

KEY REGION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Côte-Rôtie, Rhône	Co-fermented with Viognier; floral and elegant
Hermitage, Rhône	The longest-lived; mineral, smoky, austere when young
Barossa, Australia	Opulent Shiraz, candied fruit, sweet oak
Uco Valley, Argentina	Altitude and freshness; pronounced pepper
Stellenbosch, South Africa	A middle style with a smoky character

PROFILE



FOOD PAIRINGS

- ◆ Patagonian lamb
- ◆ Chorizo and grilled offal
- ◆ Spiced stews
- ◆ Grilled aubergine
- ◆ Mild blue cheeses

SERVING

16–18 °C. Decant young northern Rhône bottles: they gain a great deal from air.

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

If a red reminds you of freshly ground pepper, there is almost certainly cool-climate Syrah in the glass.

IF YOU LIKE THIS GRAPE, TRY ALSO

Grenache

Ripe red fruit and less tannin; suits the same kind of table

Mourvèdre

Earthier, more animal and denser

Cinsault

Light and perfumed; the gentle face of the Mediterranean

Malbec

RED · CAHORS, FRANCE

Emigrated and reinvented · Reached Mendoza in 1853 with Michel Aimé Pouget; Argentina now holds around 75 % of world plantings

In its native France, the Malbec of Cahors was a rustic, austere red, dark enough to be called «black wine». Transplanted to the altitude of Mendoza, with sharp day-night temperature swings, intense sun and dry air, it changed character: it kept the colour, gained fruit and lost its harshness. The result is not an improved French copy but, in practice, a different variety, defined by its new home.

HOW TO RECOGNISE IT

Deep purple with a bluish rim. Plum and blackberry over a floral base of violets — the Argentine marker par excellence. On the palate the texture is what sets it apart: abundant but fine-grained tannins that fill the mouth without scraping it. The altitude of the vineyard shows up as acidity and as fresher, more floral aromas.

IN THE GLASS

Plum	Blackberry	Violet	Black cherry	Cocoa	Vanilla
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KEY REGION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Luján de Cuyo, Mendoza	The cradle; old vines, ripe fruit and structure
Uco Valley, Mendoza	Gualtallary and Altamira; freshness, flowers, minerality
Salta, Cafayate	Up to 3,000 m; extreme concentration and colour
Cahors, France	Austere, earthy, with marked acidity
Río Negro, Patagonia	A lighter, spicier profile

PROFILE



FOOD PAIRINGS

- ◆ Grilled short ribs and flank steak
- ◆ Beef empanadas
- ◆ Grilled provolone
- ◆ Braised lamb
- ◆ Aged goat's cheese

SERVING

16–17°C. Uco Valley bottles take a degree less and gain definition.

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

The violet note is not suggestion: Argentine Malbec has been measured with high concentrations of β -ionone, the same compound that perfumes that flower.

IF YOU LIKE THIS GRAPE, TRY ALSO

Bonarda

Argentina's other red: juicy fruit, less tannin, very versatile

Tannat

Greater structure and firm acidity; for slow-cooked meats

Malbec from Cahors

The French original: austere, earthy and fresher

Chardonnay

WHITE · BURGUNDY, FRANCE

The chameleon · A natural crossing of Pinot Noir and Gouais Blanc

Chardonnay is a neutral variety, and that is precisely its virtue: it imposes no dominant aroma of its own but reflects the soil, the climate and every decision taken in the winery. The same grape can give the sharpest, most austere Chablis or a creamy, buttery white from California. To understand Chardonnay is to understand how much of a wine happens after the harvest.

HOW TO RECOGNISE IT

Pale yellow with green reflections in fresh versions; golden if there has been oak or lees ageing. In cool climates: green apple, lemon, chalk. In warm ones: peach, pineapple, mango. Butter and toast do not come from the grape — that is malolactic fermentation and the barrel talking.

IN THE GLASS

Green apple

Lemon

Peach

Pineapple

Butter

Hazelnut

Toast

KEY REGION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Chablis, Burgundy	Little or no oak; mineral, citric, razor-sharp
Côte de Beaune, Burgundy	Meursault and Montrachet; the most complex whites of all
Champagne, France	Blanc de blancs: finesse and ageing capacity
Sonoma Coast, USA	Ripe fruit with acidity preserved by the fog
Uco Valley, Argentina	Altitude; taut citrus and chalky notes

PROFILE

BODY

ACIDITY

SWEETNESS

ALCOHOL

AGEING

FOOD PAIRINGS

- ◆ Chicken in cream sauce
- ◆ Prawns and scallops
- ◆ Pasta with white sauces
- ◆ Sweetcorn empanadas
- ◆ Creamy cow's-milk cheeses

SERVING

10–12 °C if oaked; 8–10 °C if fresh and unoaked.

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

Malolactic fermentation converts malic acid — the green-apple one — into lactic acid, the one in yoghurt. That is where the buttery sensation comes from.

IF YOU LIKE THIS GRAPE, TRY ALSO

Chenin Blanc

Loire and South Africa; the same versatility with more acidity

Viognier

More aromatic and unctuous, with lower acidity

Sémillon

Waxy in texture; ages with remarkable elegance

Sauvignon Blanc

WHITE · LOIRE VALLEY, FRANCE

Nerve and fresh grass · Its name comes from «sauvage», wild; parent of Cabernet Sauvignon

Few varieties are so instantly recognisable. Sauvignon Blanc combines two unusual groups of compounds: pyrazines, responsible for the vegetal notes, and volatile thiols, which contribute grapefruit, passion fruit and the nuance many describe as «boxwood». It is a grape that demands coolness: in warm climates it loses its tension and turns flat.

HOW TO RECOGNISE IT

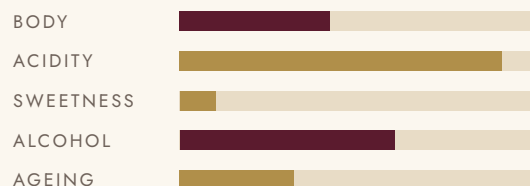
Very pale yellow, almost green. An explosive, direct nose that needs no swirling. On the palate the acidity is high, almost cutting, and the finish leaves a saline impression. Its aromatic intensity arrives immediately; it rarely needs waiting for.

IN THE GLASS

Grapefruit	Lime	Passion fruit	Cut grass	Asparagus
Blackcurrant leaf	Flint			

KEY REGION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Sancerre, Loire	Limestone soils; mineral, restrained, elegant
Pouilly-Fumé, Loire	The smoky note characteristic of flint
Marlborough, New Zealand	A tropical explosion; the style that changed the variety
Casablanca, Chile	Pacific influence; citric and herbal
Bordeaux (Graves)	Blended with Sémillon and aged in barrel

PROFILE



FOOD PAIRINGS

- ◆ Fresh goat's cheese
- ◆ Ceviche and raw fish
- ◆ Asparagus
- ◆ Salads with vinaigrette
- ◆ Sushi

SERVING

7–9 °C. Drink young; most reach their peak before their third year.

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

The goat's cheese of the Loire and Sancerre grew up a few kilometres apart. It is the most quoted regional pairing in the world, and it works.

IF YOU LIKE THIS GRAPE, TRY ALSO

Verdejo

Rueda, Spain; herbal, with a noble bitterness on the finish

Grüner Veltliner

Austria; white pepper and fresh garden pea

Albariño

Rías Baixas; citric and saline, a little rounder

Riesling

WHITE · RHINELAND, GERMANY

The longest-lived white · Recorded in writing since 1435; capable of ageing fifty years

Riesling is probably the most underrated white variety and the one most admired by professionals. It combines very high acidity with floral and citrus aromas of great precision, and it can be vinified at any point on the sweetness scale without losing balance: the residual sugar is held up by the acidity instead of cloying. It almost never sees oak, because it does not need it.

HOW TO RECOGNISE IT

Pale yellow, very clean. Lime, apple, orange blossom and, with the years, a note of kerosene or petrol that sounds strange written down but which tasters regard as a hallmark of quality and maturity. On the palate, acidity is the first and last thing you notice.

IN THE GLASS

Lime	Green apple	White peach	Orange blossom	Honey
Petrol	Ginger			

KEY REGION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Mosel, Germany	Steep slate; low alcohol, sweetness and tension
Rheingau, Germany	A firmer, drier style
Alsace, France	Usually dry, with more body
Clare Valley, Australia	Dry, austere, pure lime
Finger Lakes, USA	Cold continental climate; intensely aromatic

PROFILE



FOOD PAIRINGS

- ◆ Spicy Thai and Korean cooking
- ◆ Sweet-and-sour pork
- ◆ Sushi and sashimi
- ◆ Duck with fruit
- ◆ Apple tart (with the sweet versions)

SERVING

8–10 °C. The sweet versions a little colder: 7–8 °C.

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

The German scale ranks wines by the ripeness of the grape: Kabinett, Spätlese, Auslese, Beerenauslese and Trockenbeerenauslese. «Trocken» on the label means the wine was fermented dry.

IF YOU LIKE THIS GRAPE, TRY ALSO

Chenin Blanc

Vouvray; the same sweetness scale with a quince profile

Grüner Veltliner

Dry and spicy; shares its acidity and versatility

Torrontés

Argentina; highly aromatic, floral, always dry on the palate

IV

PART FOUR

The regions

The same Cabernet does not taste the same in Bordeaux as in Napa. This is the map of those differences: eight chapters, country by country and appellation by appellation.

EUROPE: FRANCE, ITALY, IBERIA AND THE CENTRE

THE AMERICAS: ARGENTINA, CHILE, URUGUAY AND THE
UNITED STATES

THE DEEP SOUTH: OCEANIA AND SOUTH AFRICA



PART FOUR · INTRODUCTION

Appellations and systems of origin

What each abbreviation on the label does — and does not — guarantee

Before touring the map it helps to understand how it was drawn. Every country organises its wines with its own system of appellations, and those systems answer to different philosophies: some regulate the place and everything done within it, others merely certify where the grapes came from. Confusing them leads you to expect guarantees an abbreviation does not offer.

The European model: place above all

France formalised the idea of the *appellation d'origine contrôlée* in 1935, and with it a premise the rest of Europe adopted: what defines a wine is the place where it is born. An AOC — now AOP in Community nomenclature — does not certify quality but **typicity**. It delimits a territory and stipulates which varieties may be planted, at what maximum yield, at what minimum alcohol and sometimes with what ageing. The principle is that two bottles from the same appellation ought to resemble each other more than either resembles a wine from outside it.

Hence a consequence that surprises anyone arriving from the New World: **European labels hardly ever state the variety**. They state the place, and the place implies the variety. Sancerre means Sauvignon Blanc; Chablis, Chardonnay; Pauillac, a Cabernet Sauvignon-led blend. Learning half a dozen of those equivalences solves a good part of the shelf.

Italy: the pyramid and its famous exception

The Italian system has four rungs — **Vino, IGT, DOC and DOCG**, the last with a numbered neck seal — and follows the same French logic, with one important caveat: the rung does not always reflect the ambition of the wine. In the 1970s, producers in Bolgheri and Chianti began planting Cabernet Sauvignon and Merlot, varieties not permitted by their regulations, and had to bottle as plain *vino da tavola* wines that cost more than any DOCG. The system eventually adapted and created the IGT category to accommodate them. The practical moral still holds: in Italy, look at the producer and the zone before the abbreviation.

Spain: a different axis, that of time

The Spanish peculiarity is that its best-known classification rests not on origin but on **ageing time**. A *Joven* reaches the market with no time in wood; a **Crianza** spends at least two years between barrel and bottle; a **Reserva**, three; and a **Gran Reserva**, five, with a minimum of eighteen months in barrel. The exact periods vary by appellation.

It is a convenient system and also a limited one: it guarantees time, not quality of origin. That is why many modern producers have abandoned it and label their best wines with the name of the vineyard. In Rioja, since 2017, there are also the mentions *Viñedo Singular*, *Vino de Pueblo* and *Vino de Zona*, which bring the system closer to the French model.

The New World: certifying origin, not method

The United States, Australia, Argentina and Chile share a far more permissive approach. An *American Viticultural Area* or an Australian *Geographical Indication* **delimits a territory but does not regulate varieties, yields or methods**: they say where the grapes grew, not what was done with them. The complementary rules are about percentages: for the label to carry the name of the zone, at least 85 % of the fruit must come from there; if a variety is named, it must account for 75 % of the contents — 90 % in Oregon; and if a vintage is named, 95 % of the fruit must be from that year.

COUNTRY	SYSTEM	WHAT IT REGULATES
France	AOC / AOP	Zone, varieties, yield, alcohol and ageing
Italy	DOC and DOCG	As France, with four rungs and a neck seal
Spain	DO and DOCa	Zone and varieties, plus an ageing scale
Portugal	DOC	Zone and authorised indigenous varieties
Germany	Prädikat and VDP	Grape ripeness; the VDP adds a parcel hierarchy
United States	AVA	Geographical origin only (85 % of the fruit)
Australia	GI	Geographical origin only (85 % of the fruit)
Argentina	IG and DOC	Origin; the DOCs add variety and yield
Chile	DO plus mentions	Valley, plus the Costa, Entre Cordilleras and Andes mentions

HOW TO USE THIS

A European abbreviation tells you a good deal about *what to expect* in the glass; a New World one tells you mostly *where it comes from*. In the first case the appellation is a promise of style; in the second, style is defined by the producer. That is why, outside Europe, the name of the winery is the most informative thing on the label.

CHAPTER TEN

France

The model the whole world copied

France did not invent wine, but it did invent the way we think about it. The idea that a particular place — rather than a brand or a variety — is what defines a wine was born here, was codified in the *appellation* system in 1935 and ended up being exported to every producing country. That is why it makes sense to begin with France: its regions are the vocabulary in which the rest of the world explains itself.



Orientation sketch; not a map to scale

REGION	DISTINCTIVE TRAIT
Bordeaux	Red blends of Cabernet and Merlot; the <i>château</i> model
Burgundy	Pinot Noir and Chardonnay parcel by parcel; terroir taken to its limit
Champagne	The traditional-method sparkling wine that defined the category
Rhône Valley	Syrah in the north, Grenache-led blends in the south
Loire Valley	The river of white wine: Sauvignon, Chenin and Melon
Alsace	Varietal whites with a Germanic profile and a clear label
Languedoc-Roussillon	The country's volume and, today, its most restless zone

Bordeaux

FRANCE · ATLANTIC SOUTH-WEST

The region that turned wine into an investment · Some 110,000 hectares on both banks of the Garonne

Bordeaux is, above all, a lesson in blending. None of its varieties suffices on its own: Cabernet Sauvignon brings structure and ageing capacity, Merlot supplies flesh and roundness, Cabernet Franc adds perfume. The proportions between them change according to which bank of the river you are on, and that geographical detail organises the whole region.

THE TWO BANKS

On the **Left Bank** — Médoc and Graves — the soil is deep gravel, warm and free-draining, which suits the late ripening of Cabernet Sauvignon: that variety rules there, and the wines are firm, tannic and long-lived. On the **Right Bank** — Pomerol and Saint-Émilion — clay and limestone predominate, cooler soils where Merlot ripens better and gives fleshier wines that are approachable young.

IN THE GLASS

A classic Bordeaux does not set out to impress: it sets out to last. Restrained black fruit, cedar, graphite and tobacco, with marked acidity and a tannin that can seem austere in youth. It is a style built for the table and for time, not for a solitary glass. Vintages matter more here than in almost any other region, because the Atlantic climate is irregular.

THE 1855 CLASSIFICATION

Drawn up for the Universal Exposition on the basis of the prices the wines were fetching, it ranked the *châteaux* of the Médoc into five *crus*. It remains in force almost unchanged, which makes it as prestigious as it is debatable: it reflects the market of 170 years ago. Saint-Émilion, by contrast, revises its classification every ten years.

APPELLATION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Pauillac	Cabernet-dominant; blackcurrant, graphite and very long ageing
Margaux	The most perfumed and elegant of the Médoc
Saint-Julien	A balance between structure and finesse
Pomerol	Merlot on iron-rich clay; a texture of velvet
Saint-Émilion	Merlot and Cabernet Franc; floral and approachable
Pessac-Léognan	Serious reds and the region's finest dry whites
Sauternes	Botrytised sweet whites; honey, saffron and acidity

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Temperate maritime, irregular
SOILS	Gravel, clay and limestone
STYLE	Red blends built for ageing
AGEING	10 to 40 years for the finest
LABEL	Château plus appellation

LEADING GRAPES

Cabernet Sauvignon	Merlot	Cabernet Franc
Petit Verdot	Sémillon	Sauvignon Blanc

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A **Haut-Médoc** from a serious producer: the regional style without the *cru* price
- ◆ A young **Saint-Émilion Grand Cru**, to understand the Right Bank
- ◆ A half bottle of **Sauternes** with foie gras or blue cheese

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

A «second wine» is not a second-rate wine. The *châteaux* reserve their best parcels and barrels for the main label and bottle the rest separately, at a third of the price. It is the best value in the region.

ON THE LABEL

Cru Bourgeois

The Médoc's intermediate tier, periodically revised; good value for money

Grand Cru Classé

A classified château; by the 1855 list in the Médoc, by decennial revision in Saint-Émilion

Mis en bouteille au château

Bottled at the property, not by a merchant

Burgundy

FRANCE · CONTINENTAL EAST

Terroir taken to its limit · More than 1,200 delimited climats along a fifty-kilometre strip

If Bordeaux is the art of blending, Burgundy is the art of subtraction. Two varieties — Pinot Noir for the reds, Chardonnay for the whites — and an eight-century obsession with telling adjoining parcels apart. Cistercian monks catalogued the differences in soil long before modern geology existed, and that map is still, essentially, the one in use today.

THE PYRAMID OF APPELLATIONS

Burgundy is read from the bottom up. At the base, the **regional** appellations (Bourgogne). Above them, the **village** appellations, which carry the name of the commune (Meursault, Gevrey-Chambertin). Then the **Premier Cru** sites, distinguished parcels within a village. And at the summit the **Grand Cru** wines, barely 1 % of production, identified by the name of the parcel alone.

THE PRODUCER ABOVE THE PARCEL

Through successive inheritances, a single parcel is usually divided among dozens of owners: the Clos de Vougeot has more than eighty. Two bottles of the same Grand Cru from the same vintage can be very different. In Burgundy, more than anywhere else, the name of the *domaine* weighs as much as the name of the vineyard.

IN THE GLASS

The reds are pale, perfumed and finely tannic, with high acidity and a note of forest floor that sharpens with the years. The whites run from the citric, saline edge of Chablis to the hazelnut and butter richness of Meursault. In both cases the common thread is tension: there is never any surplus weight.

AREA	WHAT TO EXPECT
Chablis	Chardonnay on fossil-bearing limestone; mineral and unoaked
Côte de Nuits	The great reds: Gevrey, Vosne-Romanée, Chambolle
Côte de Beaune	Softer reds and the world's benchmark whites
Côte Chalonnaise	The affordable way into the Burgundian style
Mâconnais	Generous, sunny Chardonnay; Pouilly-Fuissé
Beaujolais	Gamay on granite; juicy, floral, eminently drinkable

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Cool continental
SOILS	Limestone and marl
STYLE	Varietal and parcel-driven
AGEING	5 to 25 years
LABEL	Village or parcel

LEADING GRAPES

Pinot Noir Chardonnay Gamay Aligoté

WHERE TO START

- ♦ A **Chablis** without oak: the definition of minerality
- ♦ A **Bourgogne Rouge** from a good *domaine* rather than a mediocre Premier Cru
- ♦ A **Beaujolais-Villages** or a cru such as Morgon: Burgundy at a sane price

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

Buying Burgundy by hierarchy is an expensive mistake. A generic Bourgogne from a great producer almost always beats a Premier Cru from a mediocre one. Producer first; parcel afterwards.

ON THE LABEL

Climat / Lieu-dit

The name of the parcel; standing alone and in large type, it usually means Grand Cru

Domaine vs Maison

The first vinifies its own grapes; the second also buys from others

Vieilles vignes

Old vines; no legal definition, but it usually signals greater concentration

Champagne

FRANCE · NORTH-EAST

The northern limit of European wine · A protected appellation since 1936; the name cannot be used outside the region

Champagne exists because the climate was not quite enough. At the coldest point where grapes still ripen, the base wines come out acidic and thin; a second fermentation in bottle and years on the lees turn that shortcoming into a virtue. The result is the world's benchmark sparkling wine and, technically, one of the most elaborately made wines there is.

HOW A BOTTLE IS BUILT

Almost all Champagne is a **blend**: of varieties, of parcels and of years. The house defines a style and sustains it by combining reserve wines from earlier vintages; that is why most bottles carry no year. Only in exceptional harvests is a *millésime* bottled, and it ages for far longer before release.

THE SWEETNESS SCALE

After disgorging, the *dosage* is added, and its quantity defines the category: **Brut Nature** (no added sugar), **Extra Brut**, **Brut** — the standard, up to 12 g/l — **Extra Dry**, **Sec** and **Demi-Sec**. It is worth knowing: «Extra Dry» is sweeter than «Brut», which confuses almost everybody.

IN THE GLASS

Green apple, citrus and white flowers in the youngest examples; brioche, hazelnut and bread dough when the lees ageing is prolonged. The bubble should be fine and persistent, and the acidity always high. Serve in a long-stemmed glass with a reasonably wide bowl: a narrow flute preserves the gas but hides the aroma.

CATEGORY	WHAT TO EXPECT
Blanc de blancs	Chardonnay only; fine, citric, built to age
Blanc de noirs	Black grapes only, vinified white; more body
Rosé	By bleeding or by blending with red wine; red fruit
Millésimé	A single vintage, minimum 36 months on the lees
Grand Cru	From one of the seventeen highest-rated villages
Récoltant-Manipulant	Made by the grower; RM in small type

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Cold continental, at the ripening limit
SOILS	Chalk and calcareous marl
METHOD	Traditional, in bottle
AGEING	Minimum 15 months; 36 if vintage
SERVING	8–10 °C, in a wide glass

LEADING GRAPES

Chardonnay Pinot Noir Pinot Meunier

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A **non-vintage Brut** from a house you like: it is its calling card
- ◆ A **Blanc de blancs**, to understand what Chardonnay contributes
- ◆ A **Crémant** from Burgundy or the Loire: same method, half the price

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

The small letters at the foot of the label reveal who actually made the bottle. **NM** is a house that buys grapes; **RM**, a grower who vinifies their own; **CM**, a cooperative.

ON THE LABEL

Brut Nature / Zéro

No added sugar; the driest and most demanding style

Dosage

Grams of sugar per litre added after disgorging

Dégorgé le...

Date of disgorging; the more recent, the livelier and younger it shows

Rhône Valley

FRANCE · SOUTH-EAST

Two regions under one name · Two hundred kilometres of river separate near-opposite styles

The Rhône divides into two halves that share little beyond the river. The north is narrow, steep and continental, and produces pure Syrah on slopes where machinery is impossible. The south is broad, Mediterranean and windswept, and works with Grenache-led blends. Confusing them leads you to expect from a bottle exactly the opposite of what it offers.

THE NORTH: SYRAH AND GRADIENT

Barely 5 % of the valley's production. The vines cling to terraces on granite, with slopes exceeding 50 %. Syrah here gives medium-bodied wines, spiced and smoky, with pronounced black pepper and an elegance that surprises anyone who knows only Australian Shiraz. In Côte-Rôtie a little white Viognier may be co-fermented, which adds floral perfume.

THE SOUTH: THE MEDITERRANEAN BLEND

Grenache rules here, accompanied by Syrah, Mourvèdre, Cinsault and a further dozen authorised varieties. The mistral, a cold dry wind that blows down the valley, keeps the bunches healthy and allows work with few treatments. Soils of large rounded pebbles store heat by day and return it at night.

IN THE GLASS

From the north: blackberry, olive, pepper and smoked bacon, with firm tannin. From the south: ripe red fruit, Mediterranean scrub — the *garrigue* — leather and generous alcohol, with a more enveloping tannin. Both gain a great deal from food and from a couple of years in bottle.

APPELLATION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Côte-Rôtie	North; floral, elegant Syrah, sometimes with Viognier
Hermitage	North; the most structured and long-lived of the valley
Cornas	North; austere and mineral, with no whites
Condrieu	North; pure Viognier, aromatic and unctuous
Châteauneuf-du-Pape	South; up to thirteen varieties, rolled pebbles, power
Gigondas and Vacqueyras	South; fresher, more affordable alternatives
Côtes-du-Rhône	South; the entry appellation, very uneven

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Continental north, Mediterranean south
SOILS	Granite north; rolled pebbles south
STYLE	Varietal north, blended south
AGEING	5 to 30 years
SERVING	16–18 °C, decant when young

LEADING GRAPES

Syrah	Grenache	Mourvèdre	Cinsault
Viognier	Marsanne	Roussanne	

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A **Crozes-Hermitage**: northern Syrah at a sane price
- ◆ A **Gigondas** rather than an expensive Châteauneuf
- ◆ A **Condrieu** if you want to meet Viognier in its homeland

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

«Côtes-du-Rhône Villages» followed by a village name — Cairanne, Rasteau, Séguret — means lower yields and is usually worth a good deal more than the generic, for very little extra money.

ON THE LABEL

Côtes-du-Rhône Villages

The intermediate tier; better still if it names the village

Cuvée / Sélection

No legal weight; it depends entirely on the producer

Syrah vs Shiraz

The same grape; the name signals the style sought, not the variety

Loire Valley

FRANCE · CENTRE AND WEST

A thousand kilometres of river and the largest catalogue of white wine in France

The Loire is not a region but a journey. From the Massif Central to the Atlantic, the river crosses soils and climates so different that the appellations at one end bear no resemblance to those at the other. What unites them is a stylistic trait: high acidity, restrained alcohol and a vocation for the table that makes these some of the most versatile wines at a meal.

FOUR STRETCHES, FOUR LOGICS

In the **Pays Nantais**, beside the ocean, the Melon grape gives Muscadet, saline and austere. In **Anjou-Saumur** and **Touraine** Chenin Blanc rules, capable of taut dry wines, long-lived sweet ones and sparkling; red Cabernet Franc appears there too. And in the **Centre-Loire**, now continental, Sauvignon Blanc reaches its most restrained form in Sancerre and Pouilly-Fumé.

CHENIN BLANC, THE CHAMELEON

Few grapes cover so much ground. With very high acidity and a natural aptitude for botrytis, Chenin can be made dry, off-dry, sweet or sparkling without losing its identity: quince, apple, linden and a note of lanolin or wax. Its sweet versions from Vouvray and the Coteaux du Layon are among the longest-lived whites in the world.

THE RED NOBODY EXPECTS

Loire Cabernet Franc — Chinon, Bourgueil, Saumur-Champigny — is light, floral and sharply acidic, with an unmistakable note of graphite and raspberry. Served cool, at 14 °C, it works with dishes almost no other red can handle: oily fish, vegetables, charcuterie.

APPELLATION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Muscadet Sèvre-et-Maine	Melon aged on lees; saline, perfect with oysters
Savennières	Dry, mineral Chenin built to age
Vouvray	Chenin at every level of sweetness; check the label
Chinon and Bourgueil	Light, floral Cabernet Franc with graphite
Sancerre	Sauvignon on limestone; restrained and mineral
Pouilly-Fumé	Sauvignon on flint; a distinctive smoky note
Coteaux du Layon	Botrytised sweet Chenin; honey and acidity

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Maritime west, continental east
SOILS	Limestone, flint, schist and sand
STYLE	Taut whites and light reds
AGEING	2 to 30 years depending on type
SERVING	8–10 °C; reds at 13–14 °C

LEADING GRAPES

Chenin Blanc	Sauvignon Blanc
Melon de Bourgogne	Cabernet Franc
Gamay	

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A **Sancerre** with goat's cheese: the regional pairing par excellence
- ◆ A **Vouvray sec**, to discover Chenin
- ◆ A slightly chilled **Chinon**, with charcuterie

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

In Vouvray the key word is in small type: *sec*, *demi-sec*, *moelleux* or *liquoreux*. If it says nothing, expect some residual sugar. It is the main source of disappointment with this appellation.

ON THE LABEL

Sur lie

Aged on the lees; in Muscadet it means more texture and complexity

Moelleux / Liquoreux

Sweet and very sweet; the upper rungs of Chenin

Crémant de Loire

Traditional-method sparkling; an excellent alternative to Champagne

Alsace

FRANCE · ON THE GERMAN BORDER

The French region that reads as German · It changed country five times between 1871 and 1945

Alsace is the French exception: its labels state the variety, its bottles are tall and slender like those of the Rhine, and its aromatic whites have more in common with Germany than with the rest of France. Geography is responsible: the Vosges block the rain coming from the west and leave Colmar among the driest towns in the country.

FOUR NOBLE VARIETIES

The appellation reserves *Grand Cru* status for Riesling, Gewürztraminer, Pinot Gris and Muscat. Riesling here gives wines that are usually dry, firmer and more alcoholic than the German versions. Gewürztraminer is unmistakable: lychee, rose and ginger, with an unctuous texture and low acidity. Pinot Gris occupies middle ground, with body and a smoky note.

THE SUGAR PROBLEM

For decades many producers left residual sugar undeclared, so that bottles presented as dry turned out to be off-dry. The region has moved towards an indicative scale on the back label, but it remains the area where it pays most to read the small print or to ask before buying.

IN THE GLASS

High aromatic intensity and an almost crystalline definition, with a dry or barely suggested finish. These are table wines par excellence: the combination of powerful aroma, acidity and a little richness makes them one of the few reliable answers to spiced Asian cooking and to charcuterie.

VARIETY OR CATEGORY	WHAT TO EXPECT
Riesling	Dry, firm, citric and mineral; the region's most serious wine
Gewürztraminer	Lychee, rose and spice; unctuous and highly aromatic
Pinot Gris	Medium to full body, smoke and stone fruit
Muscat	Dry and perfumed, like biting into a fresh grape
Pinot Blanc	Neutral and amiable; the everyday option
Vendanges Tardives	Late harvest; sweet and concentrated
Crémant d'Alsace	France's best-selling sparkling wine after Champagne

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Dry continental, sheltered by the Vosges
SOILS	A mosaic: granite, limestone, schist, sandstone
STYLE	Aromatic varietal whites
AGEING	3 to 20 years
SERVING	8–10 °C

LEADING GRAPES

Riesling	Gewürztraminer	Pinot Gris
Muscat	Pinot Blanc	Pinot Noir

WHERE TO START

- ◆ An Alsace **Riesling** beside a Mosel one: the best comparison available
- ◆ A **Gewürztraminer** with Thai food or with Munster cheese
- ◆ A **Crémant d'Alsace** as an everyday sparkling wine

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

It is the only French region where the label routinely states the variety. The reason is historical: when it returned to France in 1945 it had to rebuild an identity, and adopted the German varietal model it already knew.

ON THE LABEL

Grand Cru

Fifty-one delimited sites, for the four noble varieties only

Vendanges Tardives

Late harvest; always sweet, though the degree varies

Sélection de Grains Nobles

Berry by berry with botrytis; the sweetest tier

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Italy

Diversity turned into identity

Italy makes wine in all twenty of its administrative regions, from the Alps to Sicily, and grows more indigenous varieties than any other country: serious censuses record more than four hundred in commercial use. That abundance explains the best and the worst of its shelf. No national style sums it up, and the name of the grape is usually the only reliable clue.



Orientation sketch; not a map to scale

REGION	DISTINCTIVE TRAIT
Piedmont	Nebbiolo in Barolo and Barbaresco; the country's longest-lived reds
Tuscany	Sangiovese: Chianti, Brunello and the «super Tuscans»
Veneto	Prosecco, Soave and Amarone: volume and prestige at once
Friuli-Venezia Giulia	The most precise white wines in Italy
Campania	Aglianico and Fiano; volcanic vineyards at altitude
Puglia	Primitivo and Negroamaro; ripe fruit and restrained prices
Sicily	Nero d'Avola on the island and Nerello on the slopes of Etna

Piedmont

ITALY · ALPINE NORTH-WEST

The Burgundy of Italy · Barolo and Barbaresco were DOCG from the very first list, in 1980

At the foot of the Alps, among the autumn fogs that give the grape its name — *nebbia* — Piedmont works the way Burgundy does: one noble variety, a great many parcels and a hierarchy built on minimal differences of aspect and soil. Nebbiolo is demanding, ripens extremely late and only reaches its peak on a handful of slopes.

NEBBIOLO, THE CONTRADICTIONARY GRAPE

It gives wines of pale colour, almost orange at the rim, which mislead completely about their power: the acidity and tannin are among the highest in the wine world. On the nose, cherry, faded rose, tar and truffle. It is a red that can seem harsh in youth and that transforms utterly once past its first decade.

BAROLO AND BARBARESCO

They share a variety and lie twenty kilometres apart. Barbaresco, nearer the river and on slightly more fertile soils, ripens earlier and gives more approachable wines; its minimum ageing is two years. Barolo requires three and produces more structured, longer-lived wines. Since 2010 both appellations recognise *menzioni geografiche aggiuntive*, the equivalent of Burgundy's *climats*.

WHAT PEOPLE DRINK EVERY DAY

Nebbiolo is expensive and scarce. The region lives on **Barbera**, high in acidity and low in tannin, and on **Dolcetto**, fruitier and moderately acidic. Among the whites, Moscato d'Asti — sweet, light and barely 5.5 % alcohol — is one of the great dessert wines of the world, and one of the most underrated.

APPELLATION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Barolo DOCG	Nebbiolo; minimum 38 months' ageing. Extreme tannin and longevity
Barbaresco DOCG	Slightly more approachable Nebbiolo; 26 months' ageing
Langhe Nebbiolo	The way into the variety, without the wait or the price
Barbera d'Asti	High acidity, low tannin; excellent with food
Dolcetto d'Alba	Fruity and easy-drinking, for every day
Gavi	White Cortese; citric, dry, highly versatile
Moscato d'Asti	Sweet, lightly sparkling and low in alcohol; dessert and fruit

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Continental with autumn fog
SOILS	Calcareous marl and sandstone
STYLE	Varietal reds built to age
AGEING	10 to 40 years for Barolo
SERVING	16–18 °C, decant

LEADING GRAPES

Nebbiolo	Barbera	Dolcetto	Cortese
Moscato	Arneis		

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A **Langhe Nebbiolo**: the variety without the Barolo bill
- ◆ A **Barbera d'Asti** with pasta and tomato sauces
- ◆ A well-chilled **Moscato d'Asti** with fresh fruit

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

A young Barolo can seem hard and disconcerting. If you are opening one under ten years old, decant it two hours ahead and serve it with rich food: the tannin needs material to work on.

ON THE LABEL

Riserva

Longer ageing than the obligatory minimum; five years in Barolo

MGA

Additional geographical mention: the name of the parcel or site

Superiore

A higher minimum alcohol and often more ageing

Tuscany

ITALY · CENTRE

Sangiovese and hillsides · Chianti has had delimited borders since 1716, by decree of the Grand Duke

Tuscany is the picture almost everyone carries of Italy, and also one of its most reformed regions. For decades Chianti meant cheap wine in a straw-covered flask; today it coexists with some of the most expensive reds in the country. Through all that upheaval, the constant has been Sangiovese.

SANGIOVESE, A GRAPE OF ACIDITY

Ruby colour of medium intensity, sour cherry, sun-dried tomato, herbs and leather. Its signature is the combination of high acidity with firm tannin, which makes it extraordinarily food-friendly and a little surly away from the table. It is sensitive to place: on the calcareous hills of Chianti Classico it gives taut wines; in the warmer south it turns fleshier and more powerful.

THE THREE CAPITALS OF SANGIOVESE

Chianti Classico is the historic heart, between Florence and Siena, recognisable by the black rooster on the seal. **Brunello di Montalcino** uses a local clone, requires five years' ageing and produces the longest-lived wines. **Vino Nobile di Montepulciano** occupies the middle ground and usually offers the best value of the three.

THE SUPER TUSCANS

On the coast at Bolgheri, with a warmer maritime climate, Cabernet Sauvignon, Merlot and Cabernet Franc thrived in wines of Bordeaux style. They were born outside the rulebook, sold as table wine and ended up forcing the system to rewrite itself. Bolgheri now has its own DOC and its bottles are among the most sought-after in Italy.

APPELLATION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Chianti Classico	Hillside Sangiovese; sour cherry and herbs. Black rooster
Chianti (generic)	A far wider zone; highly variable quality
Brunello di Montalcino	Five years' ageing; powerful and very long-lived
Rosso di Montalcino	Brunello's younger sibling; far better value
Vino Nobile di Montepulciano	A balance of structure and accessibility
Bolgheri	Bordeaux blends by the sea; the «super Tuscans»
Vernaccia di San Gimignano	The region's historic white; dry and almondy

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Inland Mediterranean, with altitude
SOILS	Galestro (clay schist) and alberese
STYLE	High-acid reds with a food-driven profile
AGEING	5 to 30 years
SERVING	16–18 °C

LEADING GRAPES

Sangiovese	Cabernet Sauvignon	Merlot
Canaiolo	Vermentino	Vernaccia

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A **Chianti Classico** with ragù pasta or with pizza
- ◆ A **Rosso di Montalcino** before spending on a Brunello
- ◆ A **Bolgheri Superiore** if you like the Bordeaux profile

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

The neck seal of Chianti Classico distinguishes three tiers: black for the basic wine, silver for Riserva and gold for Gran Selezione, which must come from estate fruit and age for thirty months.

ON THE LABEL

Gallo Nero

The Chianti Classico seal; it guarantees the historic zone

Gran Selezione

The top tier since 2013; estate fruit and long ageing

IGT Toscana

The category of the super Tuscans; it implies no lesser quality

Veneto and the north-east

ITALY · NORTH-EAST

The largest wine exporter in Italy · Prosecco overtook Champagne in bottles sold in 2013

North-eastern Italy combines two worlds that rarely coexist: the industrial volume of Prosecco and Pinot Grigio, and some of the country's most singular wines, such as Amarone and the whites of Friuli. Understanding the difference between those two registers avoids almost every disappointment in this part of the shelf.

AMARONE AND THE APPASSIMENTO TECHNIQUE

Bunches of Corvina, Rondinella and Molinara are dried for three or four months on racks before fermenting. Losing water, they concentrate sugar and extract, and the resulting wine reaches 15–16 % alcohol with a dense texture and aromas of cherry in liqueur, fig and chocolate. **Ripasso** is the halfway version: a Valpolicella refermented on the skins left over from Amarone.

PROSECCO: WHAT TO LOOK FOR

It is made by the Charmat method from Glera, which preserves fruit and flowers but gives a less refined bubble than the traditional method. The difference in quality lies in the zone: **Conegliano-Valdobbiadene DOCG**, on steep hills, produces wines with real structure; the flatland **Prosecco DOC** is another matter, far simpler.

THE WHITES OF FRIULI

To the east, against the Slovenian border, Friuli makes Italy's most precise whites: Friulano, Ribolla Gialla, Sauvignon and real Pinot Grigio — the kind vinified with care rather than in bulk. It is also the modern cradle of *orange wines*, whites macerated on their skins, a tradition recovered from Georgia.

APPELLATION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Amarone della Valpolicella	Dried grapes; powerful, dense, 15–16 % alcohol
Valpolicella Ripasso	Refermented on skins; the affordable Amarone
Valpolicella Classico	Light, of fresh cherry; drink young and slightly cool
Soave Classico	Garganega from volcanic hills; almond and blossom
Conegliano-Valdobbiadene	Hillside DOCG Prosecco, with structure
Collio (Friuli)	Dry whites of great aromatic definition
Colli Orientali	Friulano and recovered indigenous varieties

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Temperate continental with Alpine and Adriatic influence
SOILS	Volcanic in Soave; limestone and moraine in Valpolicella
STYLE	From light sparkling to concentrated reds
AGEING	1 to 25 years depending on category
SERVING	6–8 °C Prosecco; 17 °C Amarone

LEADING GRAPES

Glera	Corvina	Garganega	Friulano
Ribolla Gialla	Pinot Grigio		

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A **Valpolicella Ripasso**: half the price of Amarone and much of its character
- ◆ A **Soave Classico** from a small grower, to disprove its reputation
- ◆ A **Prosecco Valdobbiadene** compared with a supermarket bottle

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

Amarone means «the great bitter one», by contrast with Recioto, the sweet and older version. Amarone was born of a mistake: a forgotten cask of Recioto fermented until no sugar was left.

ON THE LABEL

Classico

The historic central zone of the appellation; almost always better

Appassimento / Passito

Made from dried grapes; more concentration and alcohol

Extra Dry

In Prosecco, sweeter than Brut. It is the best-selling category

The south and the islands

ITALY · THE MEDITERRANEAN

From volcanic Campania to Etna · Wine was grown here a thousand years before Bordeaux

Southern Italy has moved from supplying bulk wine to northern Europe to becoming the country's most interesting zone for value. The combination of ancient indigenous varieties, vineyards at altitude and volcanic soils produces wines with a character hard to find elsewhere, still at reasonable prices.

CAMPANIA: ALTITUDE AND VOLCANO

The vineyards sit at 400–600 metres, which offsets the latitude. **Aglianico** — in Taurasi and in Basilicata's Vulture — gives reds with acidity and tannin as high as Nebbiolo's, with dark fruit and mineral smoke. Among the whites, **Fiano** brings hazelnut and wax, and **Greco di Tufo**, cutting acidity and a saline note.

ETNA, THE REGION OF THE MOMENT

On the slopes of the active volcano, between 600 and 1,000 metres, with pre-phylloxera ungrafted vines and lava soils. **Nerello Mascalese** produces pale, taut, mineral reds routinely compared to Burgundy, and **Carricante**, whites of extreme acidity. It is now one of the most sought-after areas in Europe.

PUGLIA AND VOLUME

The heel of the boot concentrates fruit and sun. **Primitivo** — genetically identical to Californian Zinfandel — gives dense reds, sweet with fruit and generous in alcohol; **Negroamaro** is more austere, with a bitter twist on the finish. They are the most affordable and most immediately comprehensible Italian reds.

APPELLATION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Taurasi (Campania)	Long-lived Aglianico; high tannin and acidity
Aglianico del Vulture	Volcanic soil in Basilicata; mineral and firm
Fiano di Avellino	A white of hazelnut and wax; ages very well
Greco di Tufo	A white of cutting acidity and a saline finish
Etna Rosso	Nerello Mascalese; pale, taut, compared to Burgundy
Primitivo di Manduria	Ripe fruit, high alcohol, sweet tannin
Cerasuolo di Vittoria	Sicily's only DOCG; light and juicy

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Warm Mediterranean, corrected by altitude
SOILS	Volcanic, limestone and red clay
STYLE	From taut reds to opulent ones
AGEING	3 to 25 years
SERVING	15–17°C

LEADING GRAPES

Aglianico	Nerello Mascalese	Primitivo	
Negroamaro	Nero d'Avola	Fiano	Greco
Carricante			

WHERE TO START

- ◆ An **Etna Rosso** if you like Pinot Noir
- ◆ A **Primitivo di Manduria** if you prefer fruit and power
- ◆ A **Fiano di Avellino** as a different white for the table

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

Etna is one of the few zones in Europe with ungrafted vines: the volcanic sand prevents phylloxera from surviving, so there are vines over a hundred years old on their own roots.

ON THE LABEL

Contrada

On Etna, the equivalent of a *climat*: a delimited parcel

Riserva

Ageing beyond the minimum; frequent in Taurasi and Aglianico

Piede franco

Ungrafted vine; usually signals old vines and low yields

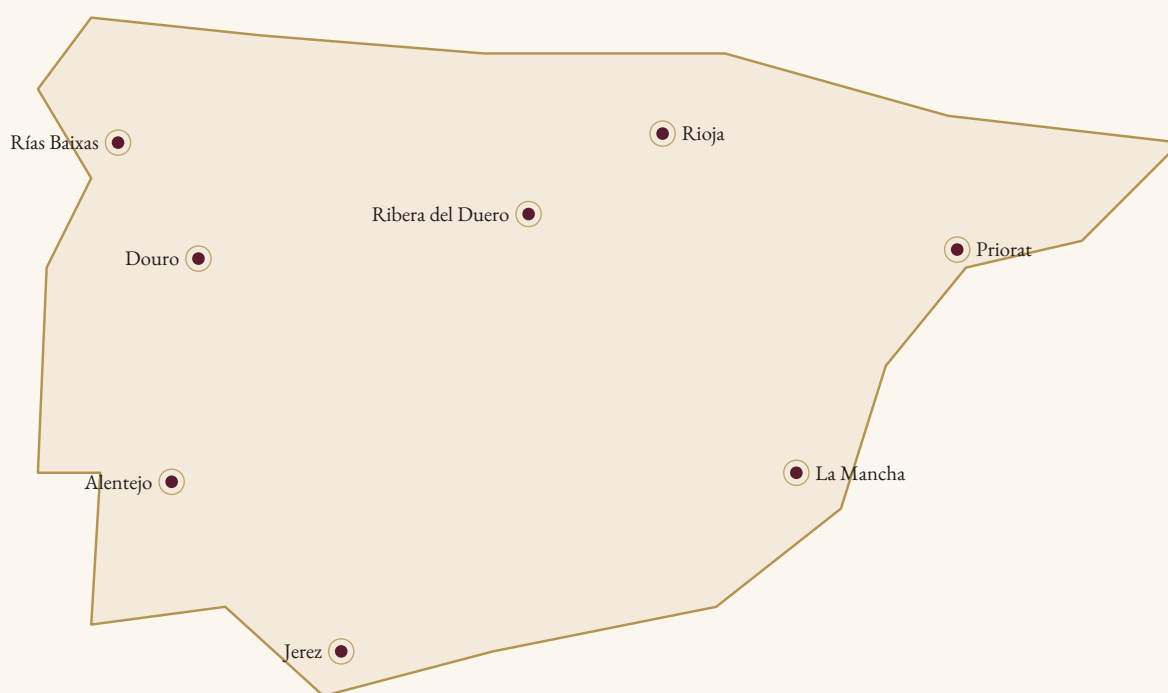
CHAPTER TWELVE

Spain and Portugal

Immense acreage, recent revolution

Spain has more hectares of vineyard than any other country in the world, though it is not the largest producer: its vines are old, planted at low density and yield little. For decades that meant cheap volume; since the 1990s it has meant something else. Portugal, far smaller, preserved a catalogue of indigenous varieties that is today its greatest asset.

THE IBERIAN PENINSULA



Orientation sketch; not a map to scale

REGION	DISTINCTIVE TRAIT
Rioja	Tempranillo and barrel ageing; the Spanish classic
Ribera del Duero	High-altitude Tempranillo; more concentration and colour
Priorat	Grenache and Carignan on slate; mineral and powerful
Rías Baixas	Atlantic Albariño; saline and citric
Jerez	Fortified wines aged under a veil of yeast; unique in the world
Douro	Port and, increasingly, dry reds of the highest order
Alentejo	Amiable, affordable reds; the Portuguese south

Rioja

SPAIN · EBRO VALLEY

The oldest appellation in Spain · Recognised in 1925; the only one with DOCa status alongside Priorat

Rioja built its identity on an imported idea: when phylloxera devastated Bordeaux at the end of the nineteenth century, French merchants crossed the Pyrenees bringing the 225-litre barrel with them. That emergency became a style, and for a century Rioja meant red wine with long time in oak, generally American.

THREE SUBZONES, THREE CLIMATES

Rioja Alta, to the west and at altitude, with Atlantic influence: fine wines with marked acidity and good ageing capacity. **Rioja Alavesa**, on calcareous soils at the foot of the sierra: the most aromatic and elegant. **Rioja Oriental** — formerly Baja — warmer and Mediterranean: ripe fruit, more alcohol and body, with Grenache to the fore.

CLASSIC AGAINST MODERN

The traditional style seeks evolved wines: brick colour, aromas of vanilla, coconut and leather, resolved tannin and many years in barrel before release. The modern style, which emerged in the 1990s, aims for deep colour, forward fruit, French oak and shorter ageing. Both coexist within the same appellation; it pays to know which one you are buying.

IN THE GLASS

Tempranillo dominates the blends, joined by Grenache, Graciano and Mazuelo. Red fruit, tobacco, leather and a sweet note of wood; medium to high acidity and silky tannin once the wine has some years. The Viura whites, long ignored, are regaining ground with barrel-aged versions of enormous longevity.

CATEGORY OR ZONE	WHAT TO EXPECT
Rioja Alta	Altitude and freshness; the finest wines for ageing
Rioja Alavesa	Calcareous soil; aromatic and elegant
Rioja Oriental	Warmer; Grenache, ripe fruit and body
Crianza	Two years in total, one in barrel
Reserva	Three years in total, one in barrel
Gran Reserva	Five years; only in outstanding vintages
Viñedo Singular	A mention since 2017; delimited parcel and old vines

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Atlantic west, Mediterranean east
SOILS	Clay-limestone, alluvial and ferrous
STYLE	Blended red with barrel ageing
AGEING	5 to 30 years
SERVING	16–17°C

LEADING GRAPES

Tempranillo	Garnacha	Graciano	Mazuelo
Viura	Malvasía		

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A **Reserva** from a traditional house: the historic taste of Rioja
- ◆ A **modern single-vineyard Rioja**, to compare philosophies
- ◆ A **barrel-aged Viura white**: a rarity that surprises

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

A twenty-year-old Gran Reserva usually costs less than a five-year-old classified Bordeaux. Rioja is probably the best place in the world to buy mature wine without paying for prestige.

ON THE LABEL

Cosechero / Joven

No wood ageing; direct fruit, for drinking soon

Vino de Pueblo

A municipal mention; 85 % of the fruit from that township

Genérico vs Singular

The latter demands a parcel, 35-year-old vines and yield control

Ribera del Duero and Castile

SPAIN · NORTHERN MESETA

Extreme altitude and diurnal range · Vineyards between 750 and 1,000 metres; frost as late as June

Along the Duero, on the Castilian plateau, Tempranillo changes its name — Tinta del País, Tinto Fino — and its character too. Altitude, harsh winters and a temperature range that exceeds 20 °C in summer produce wines far darker, more concentrated and more tannic than those of Rioja, with less apparent oak and more muscle.

WHY RIBERA IS DIFFERENT

The growing season is short and hostile: the vine buds late and runs the risk of frost well into spring. The plants respond with small bunches and thick skins. Added to the radiation of altitude, the result is deep colour, abundant tannin and an acidity preserved by cold nights.

THE OTHER CASTILES

Toro, further west and hotter still, gives wines of enormous power and high alcohol. **Rueda** has specialised in Verdejo whites: herbal, with a noble bitterness on the finish reminiscent of Sauvignon. **Bierzo**, in the north-west and already under Atlantic influence, works with Mencía, a light, floral and mineral red that has little in common with the rest of the plateau.

IN THE GLASS

Ripe black fruit, liquorice, toast and a tannic structure that demands time or food. These are wines that impress immediately and that run the opposite risk to Rioja's: excessive concentration and new wood can flatten their differences. The best producers have reduced both.

APPELLATION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Ribera del Duero	High-altitude Tinto Fino; colour, tannin and power
Toro	Warmer still; high alcohol and extreme concentration
Rueda	White Verdejo; herbal, with a noble bitterness
Bierzo	Mencía; light, floral and mineral, on slate
Cigales	Historic rosés and reds now being revived
Vinos de Castilla y León	A broad category; a refuge for singular projects

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Extreme continental, at altitude
SOILS	Clay, limestone and rolled pebbles
STYLE	Concentrated reds for ageing
AGEING	5 to 25 years
SERVING	16–18 °C, decant when young

LEADING GRAPES

Tempranillo (Tinta del País)	Verdejo	Mencía
Garnacha	Albillo	

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A **Ribera del Duero Crianza** with roast lamb
- ◆ A current-vintage **Rueda Verdejo** as an everyday white
- ◆ A **Bierzo** Mencía: the light red almost nobody expects from Spain

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

If you want a Spanish red with fruit and structure but without the sweetness of American oak, Ribera is the usual answer. If you want the opposite — evolution, leather, vanilla — go to a classic Rioja Reserva.

ON THE LABEL

Tinta del País

The local name for Tempranillo; also Tinto Fino

Roble

A brief spell in barrel, short of the Crianza minimum

100 % Verdejo

In Rueda, the mention guarantees no Sauvignon in the blend

Catalonia and the Levante

SPAIN · THE MEDITERRANEAN

From industrial Cava to cult Priorat · Two faces of the same coastline

The Spanish Mediterranean arc gathers extremes: the country's largest sparkling wine production and, a few kilometres away, one of the most expensive and scarcest appellations in Europe. The constant is Grenache, grown here for centuries, which has gone from bulk variety to prestige grape within a single generation.

PRIORAT, THE VERTICAL SLATE

Vineyards on terraces of *llicorella*, a dark slate that retains heat and forces the root down tens of metres in search of water. Yields are minimal — sometimes under a kilo per vine — and the result is Grenache and Carignan reds of enormous concentration, high alcohol and a minerality reminiscent of graphite. It is, with Rioja, Spain's only DOCa.

CAVA AND ITS ALTERNATIVES

Cava is made by the traditional method from Macabeo, Xarel·lo and Parellada, almost all of it in the Penedès. Its reputation suffered from volume and low prices, and the answer came along two routes: the **Cava de Paraje Calificado** category, with a delimited parcel and 36 months' ageing, and the departure of several producers to the independent **Corpinnat** mark.

THE LEVANTE AND CONTINENTAL GRENACHE

Further south, Montsant surrounds Priorat and offers a similar profile at a third of the price. Beyond it, Jumilla and Yecla work Monastrell in a very dry climate: dense, earthy reds of black fruit. And inland in Aragón, Cariñena and Campo de Borja have made old-vine Grenache their banner.

APPELLATION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Priorat DOCa	Grenache and Carignan on slate; concentration and minerality
Montsant	The ring around Priorat; similar profile, far better value
Penedès	The base of Cava and increasingly serious Xarel·lo whites
Cava	Traditional-method sparkling; a cross-regional DO, not a territory
Jumilla and Yecla	Dry-farmed Monastrell; dense, earthy, very affordable
Campo de Borja	Old-vine Grenache of excellent value
Empordà	By the French border; fresh reds and good rosés

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Mediterranean, dry and windy
SOILS	Slate in Priorat; limestone and sand in Penedès
STYLE	Concentrated reds and sparkling wines
AGEING	3 to 25 years
SERVING	6–8 °C Cava; 17 °C Priorat

LEADING GRAPES

Garnacha	Cariñena	Monastrell	Macabeo
Xarel·lo	Parellada		

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A **Montsant**, to taste the Priorat style without the price
- ◆ A **Cava Gran Reserva** or a Corpinnat, far above basic Cava
- ◆ An **old-vine Grenache from Aragón**: among the best value anywhere

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

Xarel·lo, treated for decades as a filler grape, turns out to be one of Spain's most interesting whites when vinified on its own: body, acidity and an elegant bitterness that gives it ageing capacity.

ON THE LABEL

DOCa / DOQ

Spain's highest category; only Rioja and Priorat

Corpinnat

A collective mark outside Cava; organic fruit and 18 months minimum

Vi de Vila

In Priorat, a village mention; equivalent to a French communal appellation

Galicia and Jerez

SPAIN · ATLANTIC AND SOUTH

The country's two extremes · From the rainy green north to the white albariza soils of the south

Two regions with nothing in common but their exceptionality. Galicia is Atlantic Spain: rain, granite and whites of cutting acidity that shatter the cliché of Spanish wine. Jerez is dry, luminous Spain, and produces a family of wines with no equivalent anywhere else in the world.

GALICIA AND ALBARIÑO

In Rías Baixas, on granite soils and with the vine trained on pergolas to ventilate the bunches, Albariño gives whites of high acidity, citric, with aromas of white peach and a saline finish. Inland, Ribeira Sacra grows Mencía on impossible terraces above the Sil, and Valdeorras is recovering Godello, a white of more body and texture that ages remarkably well.

JEREZ: BIOLOGICAL AGEING

The system has no parallel. The base wines are fortified and aged in partly filled butts, where the *flor* develops: a living layer of yeast that shields the wine from oxygen and contributes aromas of dough, almond and chamomile. If the flor is maintained, the wine is **Fino** or **Manzanilla**; if it is allowed to die and the wine oxidises, it becomes **Oloroso**. **Amontillado** passes through both stages.

THE SOLERA SYSTEM

The butts are stacked in rows and wine is always drawn from the oldest, which is topped up from the row immediately above, and so on. The result is a continuous blend of vintages: that is why a sherry carries no year and why it holds a constant profile across decades.

APPELLATION OR TYPE	WHAT TO EXPECT
Rías Baixas	Albariño; citric, saline, high acidity
Valdeorras	Godello; more body and texture, ages well
Ribeira Sacra	Mencía on terraces above the Sil; light and mineral
Fino and Manzanilla	Aged under flor; dry, saline, 15 % alcohol
Amontillado	Under flor and then oxidative; hazelnut and complexity
Oloroso	Oxidative ageing; walnut, noble wood, dry
Pedro Ximénez	Sun-dried grapes; extremely sweet, fig and molasses

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Rainy Atlantic / warm and luminous
SOILS	Granite in Galicia; calcareous albariza in Jerez
STYLE	Taut dry whites / fortified wines
AGEING	2 to 10 years / practically indefinite
SERVING	8 °C Albariño; 7–9 °C Fino

LEADING GRAPES

Albariño	Godello	Mencía	Palomino
Pedro Ximénez	Moscatel		

WHERE TO START

- ◆ An **Albariño** with shellfish: the most obvious and most effective regional pairing
- ◆ A well-chilled **Manzanilla** with cured ham or almonds
- ◆ A **dry Oloroso** with aged cheese or with consommé

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

Fino and Manzanilla are fragile wines despite their alcohol: once opened they oxidise within days. Buy them in half bottles, keep them in the fridge and treat them like a white, not like a spirit.

ON THE LABEL

En rama

Sherry neither fined nor filtered; more texture and aroma

VOS / VORS

Wines with a certified average age of 20 and 30 years

Palo Cortado

A category between Amontillado and Oloroso; scarce and sought-after

Portugal

PORTUGAL · FROM THE MINHO TO THE ALGARVE

More than 250 indigenous varieties in a country the size of Indiana

Portugal stayed clear of the international varietal wave, and today that works in its favour: almost everything it bottles is made from grapes grown nowhere else. The result is wines with profiles that are hard to confuse and, still, a value for money few countries can match.

THE DOURO, FROM PORT TO DRY RED

The Portuguese Douro valley is one of the most spectacular wine landscapes on earth: schist terraces cut by hand into vertiginous slopes. Port was born there, a wine fortified with spirit during fermentation to retain sugar. Since the 1990s the same vineyards have also produced dry reds — Touriga Nacional, Touriga Franca, Tinta Roriz — of the highest quality.

THE STYLES OF PORT

Ruby: young, fruity, aged in tank. **Tawny:** aged in barrel with slow oxidation; walnut, caramel and an amber colour, with indications of 10, 20, 30 or 40 years. **Late Bottled Vintage:** from a single year, bottled after four to six. **Vintage:** only in declared harvests, bottled after two years and with decades of evolution ahead.

THE REST OF THE COUNTRY

Vinho Verde, in the humid north-west: whites low in alcohol, high in acidity and sometimes lightly sparkling; Alvarinho is its serious version. **Dão** and **Bairrada**, in the centre, give reds of structure and acidity — Bairrada's Baga is as tannic as Nebbiolo. And the **Alentejo**, warm and flat, produces the roundest and most approachable reds, with enormous commercial success.

REGION OR STYLE	WHAT TO EXPECT
Douro DOC	Dry reds on schist; structure and dark fruit
Port Tawny 10/20 years	Oxidative; walnut, caramel, fig. Serve cool
Vintage Port	Declared vintages only; ageing of 30 years or more
Vinho Verde	Light, acidic white with a prickle; low alcohol
Alvarinho de Monção	The serious side of Vinho Verde; body and citrus
Dão and Bairrada	Reds of firm acidity and tannin; highly food-friendly
Alentejo	Warm; round reds at very competitive prices

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Atlantic north, Mediterranean south
SOILS	Schist in the Douro; granite and limestone in the centre
STYLE	Indigenous blends, dry and fortified
AGEING	2 to 40 years
SERVING	8 °C Vinho Verde; 14–16 °C Tawny

LEADING GRAPES

Touriga Nacional	Touriga Franca	Tinta Roriz	
Baga	Alvarinho	Loureiro	Arinto

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A **dry Douro red**: arguably the best value in Europe at its level
- ◆ A slightly chilled **10-year Tawny** with nut-based desserts
- ◆ An **Alvarinho**, to compare with Galician Albariño — the same grape

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

Tawny is served at 14–16 °C, not at room temperature, and lasts weeks once opened: its ageing was already oxidative. Vintage Port, by contrast, behaves like a red and must be finished within days.

ON THE LABEL

Colheita

Vintage; in Port it denotes a Tawny from a single year

Reserva

In Portugal, half a degree more alcohol and selected fruit

Quinta

Estate or property; the equivalent of a French château

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Germany, Austria and central Europe

The whites of the north and the scale of sweetness

Central Europe produces the most precise white wines on the continent and also the most misunderstood. There is a single cause: a classification system that measures the ripeness of the grape rather than the sweetness of the bottle, and which was explained badly outside its borders for decades. Once that confusion is cleared up, it opens access to some of the best value for longevity anywhere in the world.



The *Prädikat* scale ranks wines by the degrees of sugar in the must at harvest. Nothing prevents a very ripe must from being fermented to dryness: that is why a **Spätlese trocken** is a dry, powerful wine, whereas a **Kabinett** with no further indication probably carries perceptible sweetness. The word that decides is *trocken*.

COUNTRY	DISTINCTIVE TRAIT
Germany	Riesling on slate slopes; extreme acidity and low alcohol
Austria	Dry, precise Grüner Veltliner; very strict wine law
Hungary	Tokaj: botrytised sweet wines that age for centuries
Greece	Volcanic Assyrtiko from Santorini and Xinomavro from the north
Slovenia and Georgia	The amphora tradition and skin-macerated wines

Germany

GERMANY · THE RHINE BASIN AND ITS TRIBUTARIES

The country of Riesling · Around 60 % of the world's Riesling is grown here

Germany grows wine at the thermal limit of the possible, and its entire viticulture is organised around that problem: steep south-facing slopes, rivers that reflect the light and dark soils that store heat. When the equation works out, it produces whites of an aromatic precision no warm climate can imitate.

WHY RIESLING WORKS HERE

It is a late-budding, very slow-ripening variety, able to hold on to extremely high acidity while accumulating sugar and aroma. On the Mosel, on blue slate and slopes of up to 65°, it gives wines of 8 to 10 % alcohol, with residual sweetness perfectly held up by the acidity. The sensation is not of a sweet wine but of balance under tension.

THE SWEETNESS CONFUSION

This is the point that costs newcomers most. The *Prädikat* scale measures **the ripeness of the grape at harvest**, not the sugar in the bottle: a Spätlese can be dry. To know whether a wine is dry, look for the word **trocken**, or **feinherb** for off-dry. Without either, expect perceptible sweetness.

BEYOND RIESLING

Spätburgunder — Pinot Noir — now occupies more than a tenth of the German vineyard and, in Baden and the Ahr, produces reds of international standard at still reasonable prices. The **Silvaner** of Franconia is a dry, earthy and highly food-friendly white, bottled in its characteristic flask-shaped *Bocksbeutel*.

REGION OR MENTION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Mosel	Steep slate; low alcohol, extreme acidity, floral aroma
Rheingau	Firmer and drier; Riesling with structure
Pfalz	Warmer and more generous; Riesling with body and good reds
Baden	The southernmost; Spätburgunder of real quality
Franken	Dry, earthy Silvaner in a flattened bottle
VDP Grosses Gewächs	Dry wine from a top parcel; the qualitative summit
Trocken / Feinherb	Dry / off-dry; the indication that actually matters

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Cold continental, at the ripening limit
SOILS	Slate, loess, shell limestone
STYLE	Aromatic whites of high acidity
AGEING	5 to 50 years
SERVING	8–10 °C

LEADING GRAPES

Riesling	Spätburgunder	Silvaner
Grauburgunder	Weissburgunder	

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A **Mosel Kabinett**: low alcohol, light sweetness and vibrant acidity
- ◆ A **Riesling trocken** from the Rheingau, for the dry register
- ◆ A **Spätburgunder** from Baden against a Burgundy at the same price

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

The kerosene or petrol note that appears in Riesling with bottle age comes from a compound called TDN. Far from being a fault, tasters regard it as a signal of origin and of maturity handled well.

ON THE LABEL

Prädikat

The grape-ripeness scale: from Kabinett to Trockenbeerenauslese

VDP

A growers' association; its eagle on the capsule indicates parcel classification

Grosses Gewächs / GG

Dry wine from a classified vineyard; the highest tier

Austria and central Europe AUSTRIA, HUNGARY, GREECE AND NEIGHBOURS

Precision, recovery and a handful of unrepeatable varieties

Austria rebuilt its industry from scratch after the adulteration scandal of 1985 and imposed one of the strictest wine laws in the world; today its dry whites are among the most sought-after by sommeliers. Around it, Hungary, Slovenia and Greece are recovering traditions interrupted by decades of planned production.

GRÜNER VELTLINER, THE AUSTRIAN SIGNATURE

It occupies a third of the country's vineyard. It gives dry whites of firm acidity, with notes of fresh garden pea, citrus and an unmistakable white pepper. In its simple versions it is an everyday wine; in those of the Wachau and Kamptal it achieves concentration, texture and twenty years of ageing capacity. It is also one of the few whites that solves asparagus and artichoke.

THE AUSTRIAN REDS

Little known outside the country. **Blafränkisch** gives reds of high acidity, dark fruit and spiced notes, with a profile somewhere between Cabernet Franc and cool-climate Syrah. **Zweigelt**, a modern crossing, is lighter and juicier. Both are served slightly cool.

HUNGARY, GREECE AND THE BALKANS

In **Tokaj**, Hungary has produced botrytised sweet wines since the seventeenth century, measured in *puttonyos*, with acidity so high it effortlessly carries enormous concentrations of sugar. **Greece** has revalued the Assyrtiko of Santorini — a saline, mineral white from vines trained in baskets against the wind — and the Xinomavro of the north, comparable to Nebbiolo for its tannin and acidity.

REGION OR VARIETY	WHAT TO EXPECT
Wachau (Austria)	Grüner and Riesling on terraces above the Danube
Kamptal and Kremstal	A similar profile at more accessible prices
Burgenland	The reds: Blafränkisch and Zweigelt; also sweet wines
Tokaj (Hungary)	Botrytised sweet wine; very high acidity and centuries of ageing
Santorini (Greece)	Assyrtiko on volcanic soil; saline and taut
Naoussa (Greece)	Xinomavro; tannin and acidity comparable to Nebbiolo
Slovenia and Georgia	Skin-macerated wines; the amphora tradition

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Continental with Pannonian influence
SOILS	Loess, gneiss, schist and volcanic
STYLE	Precise dry whites and historic sweet wines
AGEING	3 to 30 years; centuries in Tokaj
SERVING	9–11 °C whites; 14 °C reds

LEADING GRAPES

Grüner Veltliner	Riesling	Blafränkisch	
Zweigelt	Furmint	Assyrtiko	Xinomavro

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A **Grüner Veltliner** from Kamptal with vegetables or fish
- ◆ A **Santorini Assyrtiko**: one of the most original whites in the world
- ◆ A **Tokaji Aszú 5 puttonyos** with fruit desserts or foie gras

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

The Austrian categories *Steinfeder*, *Federspiel* and *Smaragd* are exclusive to the Wachau and indicate increasing weight and alcohol: from light and aromatic to concentrated and age-worthy.

ON THE LABEL

DAC

The Austrian appellation of origin; it guarantees regional typicity

Puttonyos

In Tokaj, a measure of sugar concentration; from 3 to 6

Ried

In Austria, the name of the parcel; the equivalent of a *climat*

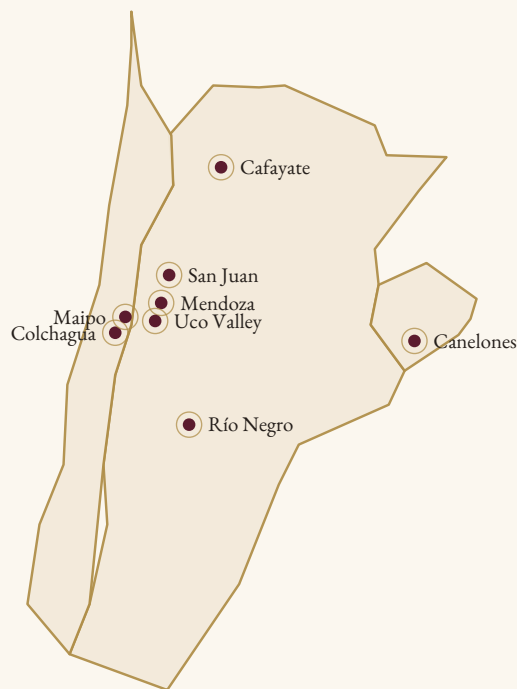
CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Argentina

The conquest of altitude

Argentina is the world's fifth-largest producer and the only major wine country whose viticulture is defined by altitude rather than latitude. Its vineyards run from 600 metres in Mendoza to 3,000 in Salta, across a high desert where rain is scarce, the sun is fierce and the water arrives from snowmelt. In that extreme setting, Malbec found a home it never had in France.

THE SOUTHERN CONE



Orientation sketch; not a map to scale

REGION	DISTINCTIVE TRAIT
Luján de Cuyo	The «first zone» of Malbec; old vines and structure
Uco Valley	Altitude, freshness and minerality; the engine of the last decade
Eastern Mendoza	The historic volume; now being reconverted
San Juan	Warm and luminous; Syrah and Bonarda
Salta and Cafayate	The highest vineyards on earth; Torrontés and Malbec
Patagonia	Neuquén and Río Negro; Pinot Noir, Merlot and sparkling wine
Chapadmalal and the coast	An emerging cool-climate Atlantic viticulture

Luján de Cuyo and Maipú

ARGENTINA · MENDOZA, THE FIRST ZONE

The cradle of Argentine Malbec · The country's first appellation of origin, in 1993

South of the city of Mendoza, between 800 and 1,100 metres, lies the area that built Malbec's reputation. Here are the country's oldest vines — many planted before 1940, ungrafted and trained on pergolas — and the historic wineries that first bet on quality over volume.

SOIL AND WATER

The soils are alluvial, formed by material carried down by the Mendoza river: layers of sand, silt and rolled stone with very little organic matter. Irrigation, traditionally by furrow with snowmelt water, allows precise control of the plant's water stress. This is an irrigated desert: without that water there would be no vineyard.

THE PROFILE OF THE FIRST ZONE

Compared with the Uco Valley, the Malbec of Luján is fleshier and less floral: ripe plum, black cherry, a base of cocoa and tobacco. The tannins are abundant and fine-grained, and alcohol usually sits around 14.5 %. This is the style the world first identified as Argentine, and it remains the most reliable partner for grilled meat.

OLD VINES

The area's most valuable asset. Vines over seventy years old produce little and do so consistently, with small bunches and deep roots that cushion climatic swings. Many of the finest Argentine wines come from specific parcels in Las Compuertas, Vistalba or Agrelo, whose names are beginning to appear on the label.

DISTRICT	WHAT TO EXPECT
Las Compuertas	The oldest vines; elegance and structure
Vistalba	Stony soils; Malbec of great depth
Agrelo	More clay; wines of body and rounded tannins
Perdriel	A balance of fruit and structure; many historic wineries
Maipú	Slightly warmer and lower; generous Malbec and Cabernet
Barrancas	Rolled-stone soils; freshness within Maipú

KEY FACTS

ALTITUDE	800 to 1,100 m
CLIMATE	Continental desert, very dry
SOILS	Poor, stony alluvium
STYLE	Fleshy, structured Malbec
AGEING	5 to 20 years

LEADING GRAPES

Malbec	Cabernet Sauvignon	Bonarda
Syrah	Chardonnay	Semillón

WHERE TO START

- ◆ An **old-vine Malbec** from Las Compuertas or Vistalba
- ◆ A **Cabernet Sauvignon from Agrelo**, badly underrated
- ◆ A **Bonarda** from a small grower: juicy fruit at a good price

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

If the back label names the district — Vistalba, Agrelo, Perdriel — rather than simply «Mendoza», it almost always signals a more carefully made wine. In Argentina, geographical specificity is the best clue to ambition.

ON THE LABEL

Pie franco

Ungrafted vine; possible because there is no active phylloxera

Parral vs espaldera

Training systems; the pergola is traditional and gives more shade

Corte / Blend

A blend of varieties; frequent with Cabernet and Petit Verdot

Uco Valley

ARGENTINA · SOUTHERN MENDOZA

The revolution of the last twenty years · Vineyards between 900 and 1,700 metres

The Uco Valley changed the conversation about Argentine wine. At the foot of the Andes, with vineyards climbing to 1,700 metres and alluvial and colluvial soils loaded with calcium carbonate, it produces Malbec with a profile distinct from the traditional one: more floral, tauter, and with a mineral salinity that rarely appears at lower altitude.

THREE SITES WORTH KNOWING

Gualtallary, in Tupungato, is the highest and the most sought-after: soils with calcium carbonate, wines of naturally elevated acidity, intense floral aroma and a saline finish. **Paraje Altamira**, with large rolled stones, gives wines of silky texture and notable depth. **San Pablo**, cooler still, produces bottles of an almost Burgundian profile.

THE STYLISTIC TURN

The Uco Valley drove a general change in Argentina: less extraction, less new oak, slightly earlier picking and a focus on the parcel. The result is a generation of Malbec at 13.5–14 % alcohol rather than 15 %, with more acidity and more transparency of origin. The word that recurs in technical sheets is *freshness*.

NOT ONLY MALBEC

Altitude favours varieties that struggle elsewhere in the country. The **Chardonnay** of Gualtallary has citric tension and chalky notes; **Cabernet Franc** has become the area's second banner, with ripe pepper, graphite and firm acidity; and **Semillón**, recovered from old vineyards, is beginning to give serious whites.

SITE OR DISTRICT	WHAT TO EXPECT
Gualtallary	The highest and most calcareous; floral, saline, high acidity
Paraje Altamira	Rolled stone; silky texture and great depth
San Pablo	Very cool; a delicate, red-fruited profile
Los Chacayes	Varied soils; structured Malbec and Cabernet Franc
La Consulta	A historic zone; Malbec with amiable fruit
Vista Flores	Intermediate; a good balance of fruit and freshness
Tunuyán and Tupungato	The departments that contain most of the sites

KEY FACTS

ALTITUDE	900 to 1,700 m
CLIMATE	Cool continental at altitude
SOILS	Alluvium with calcium carbonate
STYLE	Floral, taut, mineral Malbec
AGEING	5 to 20 years

LEADING GRAPES

Malbec	Cabernet Franc	Chardonnay
Pinot Noir	Semillón	Petit Verdot

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A **Gualtallary Malbec** and a Luján one, opened side by side
- ◆ A **Cabernet Franc** from the valley: the variety that adapted best
- ◆ A **high-altitude Chardonnay** with no oak or with discreet oak

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

The salinity many Gualtallary wines show is associated with the calcium-carbonate soils of the area. It is not salt in the literal sense but a dry, mouth-watering finish that adds a great deal at the table.

ON THE LABEL

IG (Geographical Indication)

An official delimitation; Paraje Altamira and Los Chacayes have one

Single vineyard

From one vineyard; in Argentina, a usual sign of the top range

Unoaked / concrete

Made in concrete or steel; aiming at pure fruit and texture

The north and Patagonia

ARGENTINA · SALTA, NEUQUÉN AND RÍO NEGRO

The country's two extremes · From 3,000 metres in Salta to 39° south in Río Negro

Argentina solves the same problem — finding freshness — by two opposite routes. In the north, by climbing: the vineyards of the Calchaquí Valleys are among the highest on the planet. In the south, by moving away from the equator: Patagonia has the latitude, the wind and the long days the rest of the country cannot offer.

SALTA AND THE CALCHAQUÍ VALLEYS

Cafayate sits between 1,700 and 2,000 metres, and some vineyards in Molinos exceed 3,000. Radiation is extreme and the diurnal range enormous. **Torrontés Riojano** — a natural crossing of Criolla Chica and Muscat of Alexandria — gives a highly aromatic white here, with jasmine and citrus zest, yet dry on the palate: an uncommon combination. The high-altitude Malbec is almost black in colour with powerful tannin.

PATAGONIA: NEUQUÉN AND RÍO NEGRO

The Alto Valle of Río Negro has vineyards planted since the 1920s alongside fruit farms. The climate is dry and windy, with long days and cold nights: ideal conditions for **Pinot Noir**, **Merlot** and traditional-method **sparkling wines**. The wines have less alcohol, more acidity and a profile of crisp red fruit that sets them apart immediately from the rest of the country.

THE OTHER ZONES

San Juan, warm and luminous, is the second-largest producer and has found its identity in Syrah and Bonarda. **La Rioja** concentrates much of the country's Torrontés. And on the Buenos Aires Atlantic coast, projects in Chapadmalal are experimenting with a cold maritime viticulture unprecedented in Argentina.

ZONE	WHAT TO EXPECT
Cafayate (Salta)	1,700–2,000 m; aromatic Torrontés and powerful Malbec
Molinos and Payogasta	Up to 3,000 m; extreme concentration and acidity
Alto Valle de Río Negro	Pinot Noir, Merlot and Semillón from old vines
San Patricio del Chañar	Neuquén; modern projects, Pinot and sparkling
San Juan	Warm; Syrah, Bonarda and Viognier
La Rioja	Torrontés Riojano in volume
Chapadmalal	Atlantic coast; emerging cool-climate viticulture

KEY FACTS

ALTITUDE	1,700–3,000 m north; 300 m south
CLIMATE	High desert / cold, dry and windy
SOILS	Sandy and stony / alluvial
STYLE	Aromatic and powerful / fresh and red-fruited
AGEING	3 to 15 years

LEADING GRAPES

Torrontés	Malbec	Tannat	Pinot Noir
Merlot	Semillón	Syrah	

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A well-chilled **Cafayate Torrontés** with starters and charcuterie
- ◆ A **Patagonian Pinot Noir**, among the best in South America
- ◆ A traditional-method **sparkling wine from Río Negro**

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

Torrontés disconcerts because it smells intensely sweet and is dry on the palate. Served very cold and with food it works; at room temperature the alcohol and perfume become excessive.

ON THE LABEL

Torrontés Riojano

The quality variety; there are also Sanjuanino and Mendocino

Alta gama / Reserva

Not strictly regulated in Argentina; it depends on the winery

IG Valles Calchaquíes

Covers Salta, Tucumán and Catamarca

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Chile, Uruguay and Brazil

Three different models of South American viticulture

South America is not a single block. Chile grows its vines in a dry corridor shielded by natural barriers that kept it free of phylloxera. Uruguay works in a humid Atlantic climate, with a variety it has made virtually its own. And Brazil, wetter still, found in sparkling wine the answer to a climate that makes age-worthy reds difficult.

CHILE, URUGUAY AND BRAZIL



Orientation sketch; not a map to scale

ZONE	DISTINCTIVE TRAIT
Maipo and Colchagua	Cabernet and Carmenère; the red heart of Chile
Casablanca and Leyda	Coastal and cool; Sauvignon Blanc and Pinot Noir
Itata and Bío-Bío	Southern Chile; País and Cinsault from centenarian vines
Canelones	Uruguayan Tannat on clay, beside Montevideo
Maldonado	Granite and ocean; Uruguay's freshest wines
Serra Gaúcha	Brazilian sparkling wines of real quality
Campanha	The Brazil-Uruguay border; reds with more structure

Chile

CHILE · BETWEEN THE ANDES AND THE PACIFIC

A vineyard protected by natural barriers · Phylloxera has never taken hold in its soil

Chile is a strip four thousand kilometres long, wedged between desert, mountain range, ocean and Antarctic ice. That geographical isolation kept it free of phylloxera and allowed it to preserve ungrafted vines, including varieties that all but disappeared in Europe. Its challenge has not been quality but escaping the role of reliable, cheap supplier.

FROM NORTH TO SOUTH, FROM EAST TO WEST

The traditional reading ordered the valleys from north to south. The one that best explains the wines today runs across them: **Costa**, with Pacific fog and the Humboldt current, for whites and Pinot Noir; **Entre Cordilleras**, the warm central valley, for Cabernet and Carmenère; and **Andes**, at altitude, with a wide diurnal range and colluvial soils.

CARMENÈRE, THE RECOVERED VARIETY

Brought from Bordeaux before phylloxera, it was grown for more than a century in the belief that it was Merlot. In 1994 a French ampelographer identified the error. It ripens very late and, picked too early, shows aggressive green pyrazines; done well it gives reds of black fruit, ripe pepper, spice and soft tannins. It is now the country's signature.

THE VALLEYS WORTH KNOWING

Maipo, next to Santiago, is the historic benchmark for Chilean Cabernet Sauvignon, with its minty note. **Colchagua** brings power and fruit. **Casablanca** and **San Antonio**, beside the sea, give Sauvignon Blanc and Chardonnay of firm acidity. And in the south, **Itata** and **Bío-Bío** are recovering País and Cinsault from centenarian vines.

VALLEY	WHAT TO EXPECT
Maipo Alto	Cabernet Sauvignon with a minty note; the Chilean classic
Colchagua	Warm; Carmenère and Cabernet of generous fruit
Casablanca	Coastal fog; taut Sauvignon Blanc and Chardonnay
San Antonio and Leyda	Very close to the sea; saline Pinot Noir and Sauvignon
Limarí	Semi-desert north with limestone; mineral Chardonnay
Maule	Old dry-farmed País and Carignan vines
Itata and Bío-Bío	Humid south; País and Cinsault of ancestral viticulture

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Mediterranean, with oceanic and Andean influence
SOILS	Alluvial, granitic and colluvial
STYLE	Fruity reds and coastal whites
AGEING	3 to 20 years
SERVING	16–17 °C for the reds

LEADING GRAPES

Cabernet Sauvignon	Carmenère	
Sauvignon Blanc	Chardonnay	País
Cinsault	Syrah	

WHERE TO START

- ♦ A **Maipo Alto Cabernet**, to learn the minty note
- ♦ A **Leyda Sauvignon Blanc** against a Marlborough one
- ♦ An **Itata Cinsault**: the new, lighter face of Chile

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

If a Carmenère tastes intensely of green pepper and peas, it is not badly made: it was picked too early. The variety needs two or three weeks longer than Merlot to ripen fully.

ON THE LABEL

Costa / Entre Cordilleras / Andes

Transverse mentions; they explain style better than the valley

Reserva Especial / Gran Reserva

Each winery's own scale; barely regulated

Vigno

A collective mark for Maule Carignan, from dry-farmed vines over 30 years old

Uruguay and Brazil

ATLANTIC SOUTH AMERICA

Humid viticulture built for the table · Uruguay has the highest per-capita consumption in South America

Unlike the dry, sunny Andean west, the south-east of the continent grows wine in a humid Atlantic climate. That demands more laborious viticulture and produces a different profile: less alcohol, more acidity and a vocation for the table that shows in the glass. Uruguay found its identity in a single variety; Brazil, in the bubble.

URUGUAY AND TANNAT

Arrived from Madiran, in south-west France, with Basque immigrants in 1870. Tannat found in Canelones a humid climate and clay soils that temper its natural aggression. It gives reds of deep colour, abundant tannin and high acidity, with black fruit and notes of leather. Modern versions have become more polished, and blends with Merlot or Cabernet Franc soften its structure without stripping its character.

THE URUGUAYAN ZONES

Canelones, next to Montevideo, holds most of the vineyard. **Maldonado**, with direct oceanic influence and granite soils, produces the country's freshest and most mineral wines, including good Albariño and Pinot Noir. **Carmelo** and **Colonia**, on the Uruguay river, contribute an intermediate profile.

BRAZIL: THE SERRA GAÚCHA

In Rio Grande do Sul, with nearly 1,800 millimetres of annual rainfall, viticulture is difficult for age-worthy reds but excellent for **sparkling wine**: natural acidity is high and alcohol restrained. Brazilian sparkling wines by the traditional and Charmat methods have won international awards consistently. Further north, in the Vale do São Francisco, the harvest comes twice a year.

REGION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Canelones (UY)	The heart of Tannat; clay and a humid climate
Maldonado (UY)	Granite and ocean; Albariño, Pinot Noir and fresh Tannat
Carmelo and Colonia (UY)	An intermediate profile; good Merlot and Cabernet Franc
Serra Gaúcha (BR)	Traditional-method and Charmat sparkling wines
Campanha (BR)	On the Uruguayan border; drier, reds with structure
Vale do São Francisco (BR)	Tropical; two harvests a year

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Humid, temperate Atlantic
SOILS	Clay, granite and basalt
STYLE	Tannic reds and fresh sparkling wines
AGEING	3 to 15 years
SERVING	16 °C Tannat; 7 °C sparkling

LEADING GRAPES

Tannat	Albariño	Merlot	Cabernet Franc
Chardonnay	Pinot Noir		

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A **Canelones Tannat** with barbecue or hard cheese
- ◆ A **Maldonado Albariño**: a surprise for almost anyone
- ◆ A **Serra Gaúcha sparkling wine**, of excellent value

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

Uruguayan Tannat has one of the highest polyphenol concentrations in the wine world, above even that of Madiran. Hence its near-opaque colour and its need for rich food or a few years in bottle.

ON THE LABEL

VCP

Vino de Calidad Preferente; the higher Uruguayan category

Tannat–Merlot

A very common blend; it softens the tannin without losing structure

Espumante

In Brazil, look for «tradicional» or «Charmat» on the back label

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

The United States

California and the other forty-nine

The United States is the world's fourth-largest producer and its largest consumer, and makes wine in all fifty states. But close to 80 % comes from California, whose modern history begins on a specific date: 24 May 1976, when a blind tasting held in Paris saw a Californian Chardonnay and Cabernet beat the finest French wines before an entirely French jury.



Orientation sketch; not a map to scale

ZONE	DISTINCTIVE TRAIT
Napa Valley	Benchmark Cabernet Sauvignon; the country's most expensive zone
Sonoma	More diverse and cooler; Pinot Noir, Chardonnay and Zinfandel
Central Coast	Monterey and Santa Barbara; sea fog and a cool climate
Central Valley	The volume: warm, irrigated, inexpensive
Willamette (Oregon)	Cool-climate Pinot Noir; the country's most Burgundian
Columbia Valley (Washington)	Cabernet and Syrah from a continental desert
Finger Lakes (New York)	Cool-climate Riesling beside deep lakes

Napa and Sonoma

UNITED STATES · NORTHERN CALIFORNIA

Two neighbouring counties and two philosophies · Napa has sixteen AVAs nested within fifty kilometres of valley

Napa is a narrow valley, sheltered by two ranges, where Pacific fog enters from the south and dissipates towards the north: that creates a marked thermal gradient across very few kilometres. Sonoma, larger and open to the ocean, is in fact a mosaic of climates running from frankly cold to warm.

THE CABERNET OF NAPA

On volcanic soils on the hillsides and alluvial ones on the valley floor, Cabernet Sauvignon reaches a ripeness rarely achieved in Bordeaux: candied black fruit, blackcurrant, chocolate and sweet oak, with abundant but polished tannins and 14.5–15 % alcohol. It is a generous style with an enveloping texture, very different from Bordeaux austerity.

SONOMA AND COOL CLIMATE

In **Russian River Valley** and **Sonoma Coast**, morning fog delays ripening and preserves acidity: these are among the best places in the country for Pinot Noir and Chardonnay. Inland, in **Dry Creek** and **Alexander Valley**, the climate turns warm and Zinfandel appears, with old vines exceeding a century.

ZINFANDEL, THE ADOPTED GRAPE

Genetically identical to Italian Primitivo and originally from Croatia, it reached California in the nineteenth century and became its emblematic variety. It gives reds of very ripe fruit, spice and high alcohol, with a characteristic fruity sweetness. Its pink, off-dry version, White Zinfandel, saved the old vines from being pulled out in the 1980s.

AVA	WHAT TO EXPECT
Oakville and Rutherford	The heart of Napa Cabernet; the «Rutherford dust»
Stags Leap District	Silkier tannins; winner of the 1976 tasting
Howell Mountain	Hillside and volcanic soil; structure and firm tannin
Carneros	Cool, between Napa and Sonoma; Pinot, Chardonnay and sparkling
Russian River Valley	Morning fog; benchmark Pinot Noir and Chardonnay
Sonoma Coast	Very cold and windy; the tautest wines of the area
Dry Creek Valley	Warm; old-vine Zinfandel

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Mediterranean with Pacific fog
SOILS	Volcanic on the slopes, alluvial in the valley
STYLE	Opulent Cabernet; coastal Pinot and Chardonnay
AGEING	5 to 25 years
SERVING	16–18 °C

LEADING GRAPES

Cabernet Sauvignon	Merlot	Pinot Noir
Chardonnay	Zinfandel	Sauvignon Blanc

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A **Napa Cabernet** beside a Bordeaux: the comparison that made history
- ◆ A **Russian River Pinot Noir**, easier to grasp than a Burgundy
- ◆ An **old-vine Zinfandel** from Dry Creek, with ribs or barbecue

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

Napa produces less than 4 % of California's wine but accounts for much of its value. For value for money, look at Sonoma, Paso Robles or Lodi, where the old Zinfandel vines are exceptional.

ON THE LABEL

Estate Bottled

The only mention with real legal weight; vineyard and winery in the same AVA

Reserve

Unregulated in the United States; entirely up to the producer

Meritage

A Bordeaux-variety blend; a registered trademark, not an appellation

The north-west and the east

UNITED STATES · OREGON, WASHINGTON AND NEW YORK

Beyond California · Three states with climates and styles that have nothing to do with Napa

North of California, American viticulture changes register entirely. Oregon and Washington share a latitude but not a climate: the Cascade range divides a humid, cool west from a desert, continental east. On the Atlantic coast, New York State grows grapes at the edge of the possible.

OREGON AND PINOT NOIR

The Willamette Valley, west of the Cascades, has a cool, rainy maritime climate comparable to Burgundy's, and red volcanic soils — *jory* — alongside sedimentary ones. Pinot Noir dominates production and gives wines of crisp red fruit, high natural acidity and fine tannin, in a more restrained style than the Californian. Oregon also requires 90 % of the stated variety, against the federal 75 %.

WASHINGTON: HIGH DESERT

East of the Cascades barely 200 millimetres of rain fall a year, and the entire vineyard is irrigated. Summer days are long — it lies further north than Bordeaux — and the nights cold. The result is Cabernet Sauvignon, Merlot and Syrah of intense fruit and firm acidity, with far better value than Napa. Walla Walla and Red Mountain are its best-known sub-zones.

NEW YORK AND THE FINGER LAKES

Eleven deep glacial lakes moderate the continental winter and make it possible to grow Riesling at a latitude where it should not thrive. The wines are highly aromatic, with cutting acidity and low alcohol, in a register close to the German. Long Island, with a maritime climate, specialises in Merlot and Cabernet Franc.

AVA OR ZONE	WHAT TO EXPECT
Willamette Valley (OR)	Maritime-climate Pinot Noir; the country's most Burgundian
Dundee Hills (OR)	Red volcanic soil; the most structured Pinots
Columbia Valley (WA)	A broad umbrella; desert Cabernet, Merlot and Syrah
Walla Walla (WA)	Syrah and Cabernet of a high standard
Red Mountain (WA)	Washington's warmest and most tannic
Finger Lakes (NY)	Cool-climate Riesling beside deep lakes
Long Island (NY)	Maritime; Merlot and Cabernet Franc

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Cool maritime / continental desert / cold lakeside
SOILS	Volcanic and sedimentary / alluvial and basaltic
STYLE	Restrained Pinot, firm reds, taut Riesling
AGEING	3 to 20 years
SERVING	14–16 °C reds; 9 °C Riesling

LEADING GRAPES

Pinot Noir	Chardonnay	Pinot Gris
Cabernet Sauvignon	Syrah	Merlot
Riesling		

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A **Willamette Pinot Noir**: the best alternative to mid-range Burgundy
- ◆ A **Walla Walla Syrah**, among the most interesting wines in the country
- ◆ A **dry Finger Lakes Riesling**, if you like the German style

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

Washington makes almost as much wine as Oregon and California outside the Central Valley combined, and remains little known abroad. It is probably the best-value region in the country.

ON THE LABEL

90 % varietal

Oregon's rule, stricter than the federal 75 %

Vineyard designate

The vineyard named on the label; a sign of selection

Dry Riesling

A voluntary indication in the Finger Lakes; worth looking for

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Australia, New Zealand and South Africa

The southern hemisphere that rewrote the rules

The three countries of the deep south share a similar history: decades of production aimed at volume, a qualitative turn from the 1980s and, more recently, a deliberate search for cool sites to counter the stereotype of warm, alcoholic wine. They also share very old vineyards, saved from phylloxera by isolation.



Orientation sketch; not a map to scale

REGION	DISTINCTIVE TRAIT
Barossa Valley	Opulent Shiraz from centenarian vines; the Australian classic
McLaren Vale	Shiraz and Grenache with maritime influence
Clare and Eden Valley	Dry Riesling of pure lime, at altitude
Coonawarra	Cabernet Sauvignon on <i>terra rossa</i>
Margaret River	Maritime Cabernet and Chardonnay, Bordeaux in profile
Yarra Valley and Tasmania	Cool climate; Pinot, Chardonnay, sparkling
Hunter Valley	Dry Semillon; low alcohol, extraordinary longevity

Australia

AUSTRALIA · FROM BAROSSA TO TASMANIA

Shiraz vines planted in the 1840s · Among the oldest productive vines on the planet

Australia makes wine across four thousand kilometres and in climates ranging from warm Mediterranean to the cool oceanic conditions of Tasmania. Its identity was built on Barossa Shiraz, but the country today is far more diverse: dry Riesling, Cabernet from *terra rossa*, Burgundian-profile Chardonnay and cool-climate sparkling wine.

BAROSSA AND THE ANCIENT VINES

The valley never knew phylloxera, so it retains Shiraz and Grenache vines planted in the nineteenth century, some of them ungrafted. They yield very little and very concentratedly. The classic style — candied black fruit, chocolate, liquorice and sweet American oak, at 15 % alcohol — now coexists with more restrained versions from Eden Valley, at altitude.

THE RIESLING ALMOST NOBODY ASSOCIATES WITH AUSTRALIA

In Clare and Eden Valley, at 400–500 metres and with cold nights, Riesling gives absolutely dry whites, with cutting acidity and aromas of lime and orange blossom. With ten years in bottle they develop the characteristic kerosene note. They offer some of the best value for longevity among the world's dry whites.

HUNTER VALLEY SEMILLON

A curiosity that deserves attention. It is picked very early, at barely 10–11 % alcohol, with no oak and no malolactic fermentation. Young, it is neutral and acidic, almost flavourless; at fifteen or twenty years it becomes a wine of toast, honey and candied citrus without ever having seen a barrel. There is nothing quite like it anywhere else.

REGION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Barossa Valley	Opulent old-vine Shiraz; chocolate and candied fruit
Eden Valley	At altitude; more restrained Shiraz and great Riesling
Clare Valley	Dry Riesling of pure lime and cutting acidity
Coonawarra	Terra rossa over limestone; Cabernet with eucalyptus
Margaret River	Maritime; elegant Cabernet and benchmark Chardonnay
Yarra Valley	Cool; Pinot Noir, Chardonnay and spiced Shiraz
Tasmania	The cool extreme; sparkling wine and high-acid Pinot

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	From warm Mediterranean to cool oceanic
SOILS	Terra rossa, clay, granite and ancient sand
STYLE	From opulent to taut, by region
AGEING	3 to 25 years
SERVING	16–18 °C Shiraz; 8 °C Riesling

LEADING GRAPES

Shiraz	Cabernet Sauvignon	Chardonnay
Riesling	Semillon	Grenache

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A classic **Barossa Shiraz**, to know the style that made the country famous
- ◆ A dry **Clare Valley Riesling**; it will probably surprise you
- ◆ A **Margaret River Chardonnay**, now among the world's finest

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

The minty or eucalyptus character of some Australian Cabernets is not suggestion: it has been linked to eucalyptol from the trees surrounding many vineyards, which settles on the bunches.

ON THE LABEL

Old Vine / Ancestor Vine

Barossa's voluntary scale; Ancestor requires over 125 years

GI (Geographical Indication)

The Australian origin system; 85 % of the fruit from the zone

Shiraz vs Syrah

Some producers use «Syrah» to signal a fresher style

New Zealand

NEW ZEALAND · TWO ISLANDS, ONE MARITIME CLIMATE

From nothing to a category of its own in twenty years · Marlborough defined a world style of Sauvignon Blanc

No country built a wine identity so quickly. In 1980 New Zealand barely exported wine; today its Sauvignon Blanc is a benchmark and its Pinot Noir competes with the best in the southern hemisphere. The key is a cool maritime climate, with long days, cool nights and very high luminosity owing to the southern latitude.

MARLBOROUGH AND THE AROMATIC EXPLOSION

In the north of the South Island, on alluvial soils of rolled stone, Sauvignon Blanc develops very high concentrations of volatile thiols: passion fruit, grapefruit, blackcurrant and an intense herbal note. The acidity is cutting and the finish saline. It is a style so clearly defined that it became a category: when someone says «New World Sauvignon», this is what they mean.

PINOT NOIR

Central Otago, the southernmost wine region in the world and the only continental one in the country, gives concentrated Pinot Noir of dark fruit and notes of wild thyme. **Martinborough**, on the North Island, produces more structured and earthy versions, and **Marlborough** the lightest and most floral.

WHAT COMES NEXT

The country is working not to depend on a single variety. The **Chardonnay** of Hawke's Bay and Kumeu reaches a high standard; the **Syrah** of Gimblett Gravels, on a stony riverbed, has a fresh, spiced profile closer to the northern Rhône than to Australia; and **Riesling** and **Pinot Gris** are gaining ground in the cool zones.

REGION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Marlborough	Benchmark Sauvignon Blanc; also Pinot and sparkling
Central Otago	The southernmost; concentrated, spiced Pinot Noir
Martinborough	Structured, earthy Pinot Noir
Hawke's Bay	The warmest; Chardonnay and Bordeaux blends
Gimblett Gravels	Stony riverbed; fresh Syrah and Cabernet
Waipara	Cool-climate Riesling and Pinot Gris
Nelson	A profile similar to Marlborough, softer and more aromatic

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Cool maritime, very luminous
SOILS	Stony alluvium and loess
STYLE	Aromatic whites and crisp-fruited Pinot
AGEING	2 to 15 years
SERVING	8 °C whites; 14 °C Pinot

LEADING GRAPES

Sauvignon Blanc	Pinot Noir	Chardonnay
Pinot Gris	Riesling	Syrah

WHERE TO START

- ◆ A **Marlborough Sauvignon** beside a Sancerre: the most instructive comparison there is
- ◆ A **Central Otago Pinot Noir**, with lamb or mushrooms
- ◆ A **Gimblett Gravels Syrah**, if you like the Rhône

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

Almost all New Zealand wine is bottled under screwcap, and not for economy: the country led the abandonment of cork in order to preserve the aromatic precision of its whites. A screwcap is no sign of lesser quality.

ON THE LABEL

Single vineyard

From one vineyard; frequent in the top range

Screwcap

The national standard since 2001

Sub-region

Wairau, Awatere and Southern Valleys within Marlborough

South Africa

SOUTH AFRICA · WESTERN CAPE

Wine since 1659 · The New World country with the oldest history

South Africa has been making wine for more than three and a half centuries, which places it awkwardly between the two worlds: it has European antiquity and a southern climate. After the isolation of apartheid, the industry rebuilt itself from 1994 onwards and today combines very old Chenin Blanc vineyards with a generation of producers deliberately pursuing freshness and minerality.

CHENIN BLANC, THE HIDDEN HERITAGE

South Africa has more Chenin Blanc than France itself, much of it in old dry-farmed vines — the so-called *Steent* — that for decades went into brandy and cheap table wine. Recovered, they give whites of great texture: quince, baked apple, a base of wax and firm acidity. It is now the variety that best defines the country.

PINOTAGE AND ITS REPUTATION

A crossing of Pinot Noir and Cinsault created in 1925 at Stellenbosch University. Badly made it produces notes of acetone and burnt rubber that earned it a poor name; well made it gives reds of dark fruit, coffee and smoke, with firm tannins. The «coffee style», using heavily toasted oak, is commercially successful and stylistically contested.

THE ZONES OF THE CAPE

Stellenbosch is the historic centre and produces the best reds, above all Bordeaux blends and Syrah. **Swartland**, dry and unirrigated, has become the epicentre of the new generation, with low-intervention Syrah and Chenin. **Hemel-en-Aarde**, beside the cold ocean, gives Pinot Noir and Chardonnay of great precision.

REGION	WHAT TO EXPECT
Stellenbosch	The historic centre; Bordeaux blends and serious Syrah
Swartland	Dry-farmed and low-intervention; cult Syrah and Chenin
Hemel-en-Aarde	Cold ocean; precise Pinot Noir and Chardonnay
Franschhoek	Founded by Huguenots; old Semillon and sparkling wines
Elgin	At altitude and cool; Sauvignon Blanc and Riesling
Constantia	The oldest zone; whites and the historic sweet wine
Paarl	Warm; Chenin, Syrah and good value

KEY FACTS

CLIMATE	Mediterranean with ocean wind
SOILS	Granite, schist and ancient sandstone
STYLE	Textured Chenin and spiced reds
AGEING	3 to 20 years
SERVING	9°C Chenin; 16°C reds

LEADING GRAPES

Chenin Blanc	Syrah	Cabernet Sauvignon
Pinotage	Sauvignon Blanc	Cinsault

WHERE TO START

- ◆ An **old-vine Chenin** from Swartland: the best way into the country
- ◆ A **Cape Syrah**, fresher and more spiced than the Australian
- ◆ A **Hemel-en-Aarde Pinot Noir**, to see how far South Africa reaches

SOMMELIER'S NOTE

The *Old Vine Project* seal, unique in the world, certifies vineyards over thirty-five years old and prints the exact planting date on the label. It is a far more informative guarantee than most commercial mentions.

ON THE LABEL

WO (Wine of Origin)

The South African origin system; it delimits the zone

Certified Heritage Vineyards

A seal for vines over 35 years old, with planting date

Cape Blend

A blend including a significant proportion of Pinotage



PART FIVE

The table

Wine was invented to accompany food. Six principles, a quick-reference matrix and a method for building a home cellar without overspending.

THE SIX RULES OF PAIRING

THE PAIRING MATRIX

BUILDING A CELLAR AT HOME



CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The six rules of pairing

Principles that work, and why they work

Food pairing has a reputation as an arbitrary discipline, propped up by conventions nobody ever explains. In fact it rests on a handful of reasonably well documented chemical interactions between the components of wine and those of the dish. Understanding them turns pairing into something predictable: there is no need to memorise combinations, only to know what each element does.

1 · Weight before colour

The rule of «red with meat, white with fish» is often right by accident: what actually matters is that the intensity of the wine and that of the dish should be comparable. A light Pinot Noir works with salmon and fails with a spiced stew; an oaked Chardonnay accompanies chicken in cream sauce better than many reds. Before thinking about colour, estimate the weight of both.

2 · Acidity is your best ally

An acidic wine clears the palate of fat and lifts flavour, exactly as lemon does over fried fish. That is why high-acid wines — Sauvignon Blanc, Riesling, Chianti, Champagne — are the most versatile at the table. And it is why a dish with vinegar, citrus or tomato demands a wine at least as acidic as itself: if the dish is more acidic than the wine, the wine will seem flat.

3 · Tannin looks for fat and protein

Tannins bind to proteins and lipids, and that reaction is what makes a Cabernet seem softer beside a steak and harsher beside a salad. The practical consequence is direct: **the more tannic the wine, the more fat the dish needs**. The same reaction explains why tannin clashes with fish, whose oils can accentuate a metallic aftertaste.

A THREE-MINUTE EXPERIMENT

Pour two glasses of the same tannic red. Try the first with a piece of dry bread and the second with a mouthful of aged cheese or meat. It will taste like two different wines. No theoretical explanation is as convincing as that comparison.

4 · The sweetness of the dish rules

This is the most broken rule and the one that ruins the most pairings. **The wine must be at least as sweet as the dessert**; if it is not, it will come across as acidic, bitter and skeletal. A brut sparkling wine alongside the birthday cake is a classic mistake: the cake exposes it. The solution is a Moscato d'Asti, a Sauternes, a Tokaji or a Port, according to the weight of the dessert.

5 · Heat and salt change everything

Capsaicin amplifies the perception of alcohol, tannin and bitterness. A powerful red with very spicy food therefore turns aggressive, even painful. The correct answer is a wine of **low alcohol, light sweetness and high acidity**: an off-dry Riesling or a Gewürztraminer. Salt, by contrast, works in your favour: it softens tannin and lifts fruit, which explains why cured ham goes with almost anything.

6 · The rule of shared origin

When ideas run out, look at the map. The wines and dishes of a single region evolved together over centuries and tend to fit without effort: Sancerre with Loire goat's cheese, Chianti with ragù pasta, Albariño with Galician shellfish, Malbec with grilled beef, Fino sherry with cured ham. It is neither magic nor marketing, but accumulated selection: the combinations that did not work were abandoned.

If the dish is more acidic, sweeter or more intense than the wine, the wine disappears.

THE ONE RULE THAT NEVER FAILS

The difficult combinations

PROBLEM INGREDIENT	WHY IT COMPLICATES MATTERS	WHAT USUALLY WORKS
Artichoke and asparagus	They contain compounds that turn the taste of wine metallic	Sauvignon Blanc, Grüner Veltliner
Vinegar and pickles	Their acidity exceeds that of almost any wine	Very acidic wines or a Fino sherry
Egg	The yolk coats the palate and mutes the aromas	Brut sparkling, light white
Dark chocolate	Bitterness and fat that clash with tannin	Port, Banyuls, sweet reds
Very oily fish	Can leave a metallic aftertaste with tannic reds	Dry whites, rosés, Pinot Noir
Soups and broths	They compete with the wine in liquid texture	Fino or Amontillado sherry

CHAPTER NINETEEN

The pairing matrix

Quick reference: what to open with what

The matrix condenses the principles of the previous chapter into a reference format. Each cell indicates the degree of affinity between a family of dishes and a category of wine. It does not replace judgement — the cooking method and the sauce weigh as much as the main ingredient — but it settles most everyday decisions in seconds.

	SPARKLING	LIGHT WHITE	FULL-BODIED WHITE	ROSÉ	LIGHT RED	FULL-BODIED RED	SWEET
White fish	●	●	○				
Salmon / tuna	○	○	●	○	●		
Shellfish	●	●	○	○			
Chicken and pork	○	○	●	○	●	○	
Grilled red meat					○	●	
Spiced stews	○	○	○	●	○	●	○
Vegetables and salad	○	●	○	○	○		
Fresh cheese	●	●	○	○			
Aged cheese	○		○	○	○	●	○
Blue cheese	○		○			○	●
Sweet desserts	○						●

● ideal match ○ works well empty cell · better avoided

Two warnings about its use. First: **the sauce outranks the ingredient**. Chicken with lemon and chicken in cream belong to different rows even though the meat is the same. Second: an empty cell is not a prohibition, but a combination that needs more care than a table can justify.

CHEESE AND RED WINE, A PARTIAL MYTH

The most repeated combination is also one of the least reliable. Many cheeses — blues and washed-rind ones above all — carry enough salt, fat and ammonia to flatten a delicate red. Acidic whites, sparkling wines and sweet wines handle a cheeseboard far better than a Cabernet.

Dish by dish

The recommendations below are tested starting points. In each case the safe option comes first and then a less obvious alternative that usually works just as well.

DISH	SAFE OPTION	ALTERNATIVE
Grilled and barbecued beef	Mendoza Malbec or Cabernet Sauvignon	Northern Rhône Syrah
Lamb with rosemary	Médoc Bordeaux	Rioja Reserva
Pork with mustard	Pinot Noir or Merlot	Off-dry Riesling
Roast chicken	Oaked Chardonnay	Lightly chilled Beaujolais
Pasta with tomato	Chianti Classico	Barbera d'Asti
Pasta with cream or pesto	Chardonnay or Soave	Vermentino
Pizza	Sangiovese or Bonarda	Brut sparkling
Mushroom risotto	Pinot Noir or Nebbiolo	White Burgundy
Grilled white fish	Albariño or Sauvignon Blanc	Muscadet sur lie
Salmon and tuna	Fresh Pinot Noir	Unoaked Chardonnay
Shellfish and oysters	Champagne or Muscadet	Manzanilla from Sanlúcar
Ceviche and raw fish	Sauvignon Blanc	Well-chilled Torrontés
Sushi	Dry Riesling or sparkling	Grüner Veltliner
Spicy Asian cooking	Off-dry Riesling	Gewürztraminer
Beef empanadas	Malbec or Bonarda	Rosé with structure
Fresh and goat's cheese	Sancerre	Brut nature sparkling
Hard, aged cheese	Full-bodied red	Dry Oloroso
Blue cheese	Sauternes or Port	Tokaji Aszú
Chocolate desserts	Tawny Port	Banyuls or Maury
Fruit desserts	Moscato d'Asti	Alsace Vendanges Tardives

When there are several dishes on the table — the most frequent situation and the one that most upsets the rules — the practical answer is to choose a wine of high acidity and medium structure: a brut sparkling, a dry Riesling or a light red served cool, which competes with nobody. The ambition of a perfect pairing only makes sense when there is a perfect dish to accompany.

CHAPTER TWENTY

Building a cellar at home

What to keep, how much, where and for how long

Keeping wine at home is not collecting: it is not depending on whatever happens to be on the nearest shelf the day you need a bottle. A well-considered domestic reserve holds between twelve and thirty-six bottles, renews itself and costs considerably less than people assume, because buying by the case and in advance always works out better than buying in a hurry.

The split: the 60-30-10 rule

A distribution that works for most households: **60 % wines to drink within six months**, the everyday bottles; **30 % occasion wines**, better and somewhat dearer, for guests or for something to celebrate; and **10 % for ageing**, bottles bought young to open in five or ten years. That last slice gives the most satisfaction and is the one almost nobody assembles.

A base selection of twelve bottles

QUANTITY	WHAT	WHAT FOR
2	Traditional-method brut sparkling	Aperitif, celebrations, shellfish
2	Light, acidic white (Sauvignon, Albariño)	Fish, starters, hot weather
1	Full-bodied white (oaked Chardonnay)	Poultry, white sauces, creamy cheese
1	Dry rosé	Vegetables, mixed meals, the summer table
2	Light red (Pinot Noir, Bonarda, Beaujolais)	Pork, mushrooms, charcuterie
3	Full-bodied red (Malbec, Cabernet, Syrah)	Red meat, stews, aged cheese
1	Sweet or fortified (Port, Sauternes, sherry)	Desserts, blue cheese, after dinner

BUY BETTER, NOT MORE

Two pieces of advice that save money: buy by the case of six or twelve, where the discount usually runs to 15 %, and buy age-worthy wines in their year of release, when they are at the lowest price of their whole life. A wine for keeping, bought young and waited out at home, costs half what the same bottle costs ten years later.

Where to keep the bottles

The ideal conditions are well known and rarely achievable in a house: between 12 and 14 °C, at 70 % humidity, without light, without vibration and with the bottles lying down so the cork does not dry out. What matters is understanding which of those variables really counts.

- ♦ **Stability outweighs the exact temperature.** A pantry steady at 18 °C preserves wine better than a cellar swinging between 10 and 22 °C. Thermal cycles expand the wine and push the cork.
- ♦ **Light degrades.** Ultraviolet radiation generates sulphurous compounds; that is why bottles are made of dark glass. Avoid direct light and fluorescent tubes.
- ♦ **The kitchen is the worst place in the house.** Heat, vibration from the fridge and smells. The top of an interior cupboard is usually better than any decorative rack in the dining room.
- ♦ **Lying down, except sparkling wine.** The cork must stay damp. In sparkling wine the internal pressure keeps it expanded, so the bottles can stand upright.

How long each type lasts

TYPE OF WINE	OPTIMUM WINDOW FROM THE HARVEST
Light, aromatic whites	1 to 3 years
Rosés	1 to 2 years
Non-vintage sparkling	2 to 5 years
Oaked whites	3 to 10 years
Young, light reds	2 to 5 years
Mid-range reds with barrel ageing	4 to 10 years
Reds for keeping (Bordeaux, Barolo, Rioja Gran Reserva)	8 to 30 years
Quality German Riesling	5 to 40 years
Vintage Port and botrytised sweet wines	15 to 50 years
Fino sherry and Manzanilla	Drink as soon as possible; they do not improve in bottle

The most useful rule of all

More than ninety per cent of the wine made in the world is intended to be drunk within two years of its harvest, and does not improve with time: it only loses fruit. Keeping for the sake of keeping is the commonest way to ruin a bottle. Before setting a wine aside for years it is worth having a concrete reason to believe it deserves the wait: tannic structure, high acidity and, preferably, the experience of having tasted an earlier vintage.



APPENDIX I

A taster's glossary

The terms that come up again and again

Astringency. The tactile sensation of dryness produced by tannins binding with the proteins in saliva.

Bâtonnage. Periodic stirring of the lees during ageing; it adds volume and aromas of bread.

Blending. Combining wines from different varieties, parcels or barrels to build the final wine.

Botrytis. The fungus *Botrytis cinerea*. In the right conditions it concentrates the sugar in the grape and gives the great sweet wines.

Brett. Short for *Brettanomyces*, a yeast that contributes notes of leather and farmyard; a fault at high levels.

Body. The sensation of weight and density on the palate; the result of alcohol, extract and sugar.

Carbonic maceration. Intracellular fermentation in whole bunches; it produces very fruity wines with low tannin.

Cork taint. Contamination by TCA; it recalls wet cardboard and cancels out the fruit. It affects a small percentage of bottles.

Decanting. Pouring wine into another vessel to aerate it or to separate the sediment.

Disgorging. In sparkling wine, expelling the frozen sediment from the neck before the final cork.

Extraction. The degree to which colour and tannin have been drawn from the skins during maceration.

Length. How long the flavour lingers after swallowing; measured in seconds and a good indicator of quality.

Lees. The remains of yeast that settle after fermentation; they contribute texture and aroma if kept in contact.

Malolactic. A bacterial fermentation that converts malic acid into the softer lactic acid.

Minerality. A contested descriptor; it refers to notes of chalk, flint or salt and to a dry, mouth-watering finish.

Must. Grape juice before or during fermentation.

Overripeness. Fruit picked past its point; it gives cooked fruit, high alcohol and low acidity.

Phylloxera. The insect that destroyed the European vineyard in the late nineteenth century; it forced grafting onto American rootstock.

Reduction. A lack of oxygen during ageing; it produces notes of struck match or rubber that usually blow off with air.

Retronasal. The route by which aromas reach the sense of smell from the mouth; much of «flavour» happens there.

Sulphites. Sulphur compounds with an antioxidant and antimicrobial role; present in all wine.

Tannin. A phenolic compound from skins, seeds and wood; responsible for astringency and for ageing capacity.

Terroir. The combination of soil, climate, topography and human practice that characterises a place.

Ungrafted. A vine on its own roots, not grafted; only possible where phylloxera is not active.

Varietal. A wine made predominantly from a single variety, and labelled as such.

Vintage. The year the grapes were harvested. In irregular climates it makes for marked differences between bottles of the same wine.

Volatile acidity. Acetic acid; in excess it produces a smell of vinegar or nail-polish remover.

Wood ageing. The period of maturation before release, in barrel, tank or bottle.

APPENDIX II

How to read a label

Which information is compulsory, which is useful and which is merely decorative

A label combines three layers: what the law obliges the producer to declare, what the producer considers relevant and what the marketing department adds. Telling them apart is the difference between buying informed and buying by graphic design.

The compulsory part

With variations by country, a label must always state the **origin** — appellation or region — the **alcoholic degree**, the **volume**, the **bottler or producer** and the warning about **sulphites**. The vintage, by contrast, is not always compulsory: non-vintage sparkling wines and solera-aged wines carry none by definition.

Old World against New World

ASPECT	EUROPE	THE NEW WORLD
Central element	The place: the appellation of origin	The variety and the brand
Variety	Rarely stated; implicit in the appellation	Almost always on the front
What the rules cover	Grapes, yields, ageing, methods	Generally only geographical origin
Hierarchy	Explicit: AOC, DOCG, DOCa	Practically non-existent
Quality mentions	Regulated (Reserva, Grand Cru)	Free and without legal weight

Terms with no legal weight

It is worth being sceptical by default of *Reserve* outside Spain, Italy and Portugal, and of *Selection*, *Premium*, *Old Vine*, *Winemaker's Choice*, *Cuvée Spéciale* and *Barrel Select* almost everywhere. None of these terms is regulated: they may denote real work or absolutely nothing at all.

THREE THINGS THAT DO INFORM

Alcoholic degree: a guide to the climate and the weight of the wine. **Bottled at the property:** *mis en bouteille au domaine*, *estate bottled*, *imbottigliato all'origine*; it means whoever grew the grapes also made the wine. **The name of the vineyard or site:** the more specific the declared origin, the greater the ambition usually is.

A quick label dictionary

TERM	ORIGIN	MEANING
Sec / Trocken / Secco	FR / DE / IT	Dry, with no perceptible residual sugar
Demi-sec / Halbtrocken	FR / DE	Off-dry; light but perceptible sweetness
Moelleux / Liqueux	France	Sweet and very sweet
Cru / Grand Cru	France	Classified vineyard; the scope varies by region
Vieilles vignes	France	Old vines; no legal definition
Classico	Italy	The historic central zone of the appellation
Superiore	Italy	Higher minimum alcohol and sometimes more ageing
Riserva	Italy	Ageing beyond the obligatory minimum
Crianza / Reserva	Spain	Ageing scales regulated by appellation
Cosecha / Vendimia	Spain	The year the grapes were picked
Quinta	Portugal	Estate or property
Colheita	Portugal	Vintage; in Port, a Tawny from a single year
Prädikat	Germany	The scale of grape ripeness at harvest
Gutsabfüllung	Germany	Bottled at the property
Estate Bottled	USA	Vineyard and winery under the same control and in the same AVA
Single vineyard	General	From one vineyard; usually a sign of selection
Sur lie	France	Aged on the lees; more texture
Brut Nature / Zero	Sparkling	No sugar added after disgorging

A method in four questions

Faced with an unfamiliar bottle, four questions settle almost everything before you read a single tasting note:

- ◆ **Where exactly is it from?** The more precise the delimitation — parcel before village, village before region — the higher the level of ambition.
- ◆ **What is the alcoholic degree?** Below 12.5 % it is probably a fresh, light wine; above 14.5 %, warm and full-bodied.
- ◆ **Who bottled it?** If producer and grower are the same, there is a complete chain of responsibility.
- ◆ **Which vintage is it?** In Europe it defines the climatic year; in stable climates it matters far less.

Tasting sheet

To photocopy or print; one bottle per sheet

IDENTIFICATION

Wine

Producer

Region / appellation

Variety or varieties

Vintage

Price and place of purchase

SIGHT

Colour intensity

Hue and rim

NOSE

At rest

After swirling

Dominant families

Primary / secondary / tertiary

PALATE

Sweetness

Acidity

Tannin

Alcohol

Body

Flavours in the mouth

FINISH

Length (seconds)

Dominant sensation

CONCLUSION

Balance

What would you serve it with?

Would you buy it again?

Personal note

CLOSING

Drinking with your own judgement

What remains when the book is shut

A book about wine is only useful if it makes itself unnecessary. Everything above — the five components, the influence of climate, the catalogue of varieties, the map of the regions, the rules of the table — points at a single objective: that faced with an unfamiliar bottle you can form a reasonable expectation, test it as you pour and correct it if need be. That circuit, repeated, is all that having judgement means.



Four things worth not forgetting

- ◆ **Price is not a measure of quality.** It is a measure of scarcity, prestige and cost of production. It correlates with quality only up to a point, and in blind tastings that point arrives far sooner than almost anyone expects.
- ◆ **Description is a tool, not an exam.** Naming aromas helps you remember and communicate. If you like a wine and cannot find the words, you like it just the same.
- ◆ **Context is part of the wine.** Company, food, temperature and even the glass change what you perceive. No bottle is drunk in a vacuum, and pretending otherwise is a way of impoverishing it.
- ◆ **Your palate is the final arbiter.** Scores, guides and this book are maps. The territory is in the glass in front of you.

ONE LAST RECOMMENDATION

Take two bottles of the same variety from different places — a Malbec from Luján de Cuyo and one from Gualtallary, say — and open them together. Everything set out in Part II becomes obvious within five minutes of comparison.

Ten bottles for building judgement

If you had to put together your own course on a limited budget, this run covers nearly every coordinate in this guide: two climates, two hemispheres, four structures and the full sweetness scale. There is no need to buy them together or to overspend: almost every square is covered in the mid-range of any well-stocked merchant.

BOTTLE	WHAT IT TEACHES
Loire Sauvignon Blanc	High acidity and crisp primary aromas
Oaked Chardonnay	Secondary aromas: malolactic and lees ageing
Off-dry German Riesling	How sugar coexists with acidity without cloying
Cool-climate Pinot Noir	Silky tannin and a deceptively pale colour
Malbec from Luján de Cuyo	Fine-grained texture and ripe fruit
Malbec from the Uco Valley	The same variety with more altitude and freshness
Cabernet Sauvignon from Bordeaux	Tannic structure and a restrained profile
Northern Rhône Syrah	Spice and cool climate in a powerful red
Traditional-method sparkling	Fine bubble and the aromas of long ageing
A red with ten years or more	Tertiary aromas and resolved tannin

How to carry on

- ♦ **Repeat the paired comparison once a month.** Twelve exercises a year build more judgement than any amount of reading.
- ♦ **Visit a winery at harvest.** Watching the fruit come in, smelling a tank in mid-fermentation and tasting must explains in an afternoon what a chapter can only describe.
- ♦ **Taste with other people.** Hearing how someone else names an aroma is the fastest way to widen your own vocabulary.
- ♦ **Keep the labels you liked.** With thirty or forty, the pattern of your preferences becomes obvious: region, style, producer.



Cheers.



VAKO CLUB

The World of the Glass

AN ENTHUSIAST'S GUIDE · 2026 EDITION